

Little Kids, Big Adventures: A Guide to Family Hikes Around Knoxville

**The Tennessee Valley, Cumberland Plateau, and Great Smoky Mountains National
Park**

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Front Matter

Dedication

To Jonah and Ayla.

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Getting Ready for Your First Hike

A story about a hike

Figures included in this chapter:

- jo boat.jpeg
- ayla mae run edited.JPG
- ayla-flowers.jpg

Picture this: A sunny day in nature with your family. Your kids happily climb up and over rocks, stopping only to splash in creeks. At the end, you have a picnic on the grass on a perfect, mild but warm day without a bug to be found.

Record Scratch

Sure, we'd all love for the above vision to be reality, but the truth is almost always a bit messier and with unexpected bumps in the road.

If you're like us, you might be ready to throw in the towel before you even leave home. We've been there.

However, we've also grown as a family who hikes, honed the process, and adjusted our expectations. And sometimes the weather is just right, we and the kiddos are having a great time, and, every once in a while, there really isn't a bug in sight.

We wrote this to help our friends (and you!)

After moving to Knoxville as a very young famiy in 2018, our first trip to Ijams introduced us to Knoxville's incredible outdoor spaces. Katie discovered Seven Islands, and it was awesome—and close to home. A camping trip at Frozen Head opened our eyes. Later, visiting the Smokies sealed the deal: hiking helped us to feel connected to and later to love where we live.

We don't think we're very special in this respect (and in most others!): One of the many joys of writing this book was discovering that we'd hiked all 30 of the trails in it.

As we transitioned from newcomers to becoming established, we were increasingly asked questions by our friends:

Where should we hike with our kids?

and

What do I need to hike with our kids?

This book is meant to answer those questions. But, as a sneak preview, we picked out 30 trails with an eye not only toward the trails that are scenic and exciting, but also those that are likely to balance driving distance, crowds, and kid-friendly characteristics. And, one of the many great parts about hiking is that you don't need much to get started. Indeed, you may not need anything at all.

Whom this book is for

This book is for families and others caring for children who are looking for an accessible introduction to getting started hiking around Knoxville. Furthermore, this book is also for those with a few favorite trails looking to do and learn more—find longer, more challenging hikes or be introduced to hidden gems.

Because this book is for those new to hiking and those with some mud on their shoes, we've included a wide range of hikes, from those shorter than a mile on paved trails to epic expeditions into the Smokies. Additionally, we've noted trails that are stroller-friendly or accessible for families with additional needs.

Read on for things to consider for your first hike (you don't need much!) and some recommendations for choosing a hike.

Getting Ready for Your First Hike

Figures included in this chapter:

- kids running.jpg
- kids-looking-down.jpeg
- snacks.jpeg

You don't need fancy gear!

There's a little secret in the hiking world. You don't need a lot to get started. Indeed, you may not need anything *new* at all.

Our view is that you don't need anything special to enjoy your first hike. With the right trail and a few basics, you'll be ready for an adventure.

First, though, there's another little secret we need to share.

You don't need to be an experienced hiker to hike with little ones

Hiking can be different from other physical activities in that it is not a competition. Instead, it is about experiencing the outdoors in our own way.

This applies to beginners and to the most experienced hikers; a common saying shared among long-distance hikers is to *hike your own hike*. This means that each person hiking will hike in their way, and that there is not anything like a correct way to lace up your shoes and to get outdoors with your family. If this applies to long-distance hikers, we think it doubly applies to families hiking with littles! Hike your own hike.

Let kids take the lead

To help your kids develop a love for hiking and the outdoors, let them take the lead. Let them develop their own interests and explore their own curiosities when you go on a hike. Sometimes this might mean playing in a creek for half of your planned hiking time.

Be choosy about the when and where

One of the benefits of living close to great hiking opportunities is that we can be a little choosy about when and where we hike. While we are card carrying members of the puddle splashing club, we also appreciate that our littles may have a better time when it is not 50°F and rainy. Does it look like it is going to rain all day, border on being too cold, or be oppressively hot? You can choose another day to hike; we have enough good weather that we can avoid the less-than-ideal days.

Plan for the essentials

At a minimum, the following items are essential for hikes when the weather is good and you are close to home:

- Water
- Snacks
- A waist pack or backpack

Older kids may like to carry some of these—especially the snacks!

When taking on a lengthier hike or traveling farther from home, we like asking ourselves the following questions:

What has the weather been? *What is the weather forecast? Is it bug season?*

These can help you to pack appropriately.

The appendix has some recommendations for a basic first-aid kit as well as recommendations for some optional items you may wish to bring.

Check before you go

Trail access and conditions can change rapidly due to weather, maintenance, or seasonal closures, and—especially for the Great Smoky Mountains National Park—federal funding circumstances!

Before heading out, consider the following:

- Visit official park websites for up-to-date trail status.
- Call the local ranger station or visitor center to confirm access and hours.
- Review recent weather forecasts and trail reports for hazards.

Embrace serendipity

It's good to have a plan, but don't be surprised if something better comes along! Maybe you hike further than you thought you would, or perhaps your child surprises you (and themselves!) by taking some time to rock hop across a creek, follow animal tracks, or look at plants and flowers. Be ready to follow your child's lead—whether that means stopping to watch a butterfly or counting animal tracks. These moments often become the most cherished.

Select advice

We asked some local hiking experts to share some additional advice. Here's what they said:

- “Kids need to find things they love on hiking.” - Finn (3)
- “Find rocks while hiking.” - Ruth (5)
- “When possible, swim in the waterfalls.” - Ruth (5)
- “It's important to go off the trail.” - Ruth (5)
- “If your baby can walk a little bit, then let them walk.” - Jonah (age 6)
- “Make sure to run and also look for bears.” - Levi (7)
- “You might want to bring pants and a sweatshirt with a hood. Because that one time I brought no pants and a sweatshirt with no hood.” - G.H. (9)
- “Games and stories are better when made up on the fly.” - D. (9)

The next chapter offers some guidance on how to pick a trail (and how to use this book).

Finding a Hike

Figures included in this chapter:

- kids-swamp.jpg
- rocky-trail.jpg
- kids-walking-abrams.jpeg

Lists of *the best* hikes are helpful, but they can lead you to trails that are far away, crowded, and not suited to young kids. Furthermore, what even is *the best* trail to kids?

We bet you’ve had the experience on a family trip to someplace special only for your kiddo to be captivated by the stairs near the entrance or some random stick on the side of the trail.

There’s something similar when it comes to finding a hike: Which hike is the best can be really hard to predict in advance!

Still, we think you can set yourself up for success: We picked the hikes that are in the sweet spot for parents of younger children: not too far away, not so challenging as to be discouraging to kids and their parents; near amenities; and scenic and rewarding to accomplish.

Let’s start with where these hikes are located.

Where the hikes are

All of the hikes are near Knoxville—from just a few minutes to within an hour or two drive (but no longer). Following our focus on hiking with younger children, most of the hikes are within an hour’s drive of Knoxville.

They are in three regions:

- **In and around Knoxville:** Hikes within the Knoxville city limits to those within a 30-minute drive.
- **The Cumberland Plateau:** An often under-appreciated but fantastic region of rock outcroppings and wild rivers to the West and North of Knoxville. The hikes in this region are from around one to two hours from Knoxville, with most being close to one hour.
- **The Great Smoky Mountains National Park:** The most-visited and the most biodiverse national park—right in Knoxville’s backyard. These are mostly around an hour from Knoxville, though a few are closer to two hours.

Choosing where to hike

Some trails are short, flat, and on a paved surface. Others are longer, steeper, or rockier. How do you find which one is best for you?

This book has three sections, one each for hikes in and around Knoxville, on the Cumberland Plateau, and in the Great Smoky Mountains National Park. Within each section, we organized each hike loosely along the lines of those we'd recommend first.

Thus, the first few hikes in each section are what we think of as “sure bets.” Get the weather right, pack a bunch of snacks, and we think you'll likely have a good time. We also created a list of Top 5 Hikes that can help with choosing where to hike first.

For example, Seven Islands in Knoxville is a reliable choice, with paved paths, beautiful views, and plenty of spots for kids to explore. Indeed, if you haven't hiked there yet and the weather is good, we recommend you stop reading now and head out!

Each chapter has a lot of information you can use to choose your hike—particularly information in the **Overview** and **Key Characteristics** sections. You can use those for inspiration. All of the key characteristics are also provided in a table in the Overview section for easy review. We go into more depth on these and other considerations for your first hike in the next section.

How to Use This Book

What Each Chapter Includes

Overview

Each of the chapters for hikes starts with an *Overview* that give a sense for “look and feel” of the hike.

Key Characteristics

After each overview is a table with *Key Characteristics* of the trail, including for which ages of children the hike is best.

- *Toddlers*: One-two year-olds who can walk some of the trail (being carried for other parts) or all of short trails.
- *Little kids*: Two- four or five years who can walk all of short trails and even some parts of lengthier trails.
- *Big kids*: Four -eight or nine who can walk longer distances and who are up for bigger challenges
- *Pre-teens and older*: Eight or nine and up

Of course, you may also choose to carry your toddler, little kid, or younger big kid for some or all of these hikes.

The key characteristics also include the length of the hike, approximately how long it takes to hike, the elevation change (Flat, Gentle, Moderate, Steep, and Very Steep), whether pets are allowed a parking pass required, and the presence of a restroom. Finally, we also note the accessibility of each trail.

Understanding Accessibility: The accessibility rating describes the trail surface and terrain to help you determine whether the trail works for your family’s needs.

- “Accessible” trails are fully paved and relatively flat, suitable for wheelchairs, strollers, and mobility devices.
- “Partially accessible” trails may be paved for a portion of the route or have graded gravel surfaces that work for some wheeled devices.

- “Not accessible” trails have unpaved, uneven, rocky, or steep terrain that makes them unsuitable for wheels.

These ratings are intended to help you plan hikes that match your needs, whether you’re pushing a stroller, using a wheelchair, or simply prefer smoother surfaces.

Trail Maps and Photos

Each hike has a *trail map*. These should be pretty straightforward to use. Trailheads—the starting points for the hikes—are marked with a green dot, and the trail is in red, with key features of the trail noted along the way. We also include one or more photos for each hike; we tried to select these to show what makes the hike unique.

Each chapter also includes directions to the trailhead with a street address or GPS coordinates. In some cases, remote trailheads without street addresses use a **Google Maps Plus code**—a short, alphanumeric code (like “W2HG+M9”) that pinpoints an exact location anywhere in the world. Plus codes only work in Google Maps, so if you use a different navigation app, use the GPS coordinates instead.

Call outs

The hikes are through areas rich in natural and human history, and while we felt comfortable accurately describing many of these elements, we felt we had to enlist the help of friends and colleagues for others—for which we have “*call outs*”. Look for these in the call-outs in most of the chapters, and consider sharing parts of them with your little hikers.

Doing more

Each chapter concludes with one or more things to do *nearby*, from places to grab a bite to eat to other, nearby hikes to consider.

The next two chapters provide the key characteristics for all of the hikes in the book as and Top 5 hikes in different categories, respectively.

Overview of the Hikes

This overview table includes key information about the 30 hikes. Please see each chapter description for more details, including information about whether pets are allowed, parking passes are required, the availability of restrooms, and the accessibility of the trails for strollers and wheelchairs.

Overview of the Hikes

Trail #	Trail Name	Location	Time from Knoxville	Trail Distance (Mi.)	Elevation	Best Ages
1	Seven Islands	Seven Islands State Birding Park	30 mins	2.3	Gentle	Toddlers, Little kids, and Big kids
2	Ijams Riverside	Ijams Nature Center	10-15 mins	1.0	Moderate	Toddlers and Little kids
3	Lakeshore Park	Lakeshore Park	10-15 mins	2.2	Gentle	Toddlers, Little kids, and Big kids
4	High Ground Park	High Ground Park	10-15 mins	0.7	Gentle	Toddlers and Little kids
5	UT Arboretum	University of Tennessee Arboretum	25-30 mins	0.9	Gentle	Toddlers and Little kids
6	Knox-Blount Greenway	Knox-Blount Greenway	5-10 mins	2.3	Gentle	Toddlers and Little kids
7	Sequoyah Park	Sequoyah Park	10-15 mins	2.1	Flat	Toddlers and Little kids
8	Ijams Crag	Ijams Nature Center	10-15 mins	1.5	Moderate	Little kids and Big kids
9	William Hastie	William Hastie Natural Area	15 mins	1.3	Flat	Toddlers and Little kids

Trail #	Trail Name	Location	Time from Knoxville	Trail Distance (Mi.)	Elevation	Best Ages
10	Sharp's Ridge	Sharp's Ridge Memorial Park	10 mins	2.3	Moderate	Little kids
11	Norris Dam	Norris Dam State Park	30 mins	2.3	Gentle	Little kids and Big kids
12	House Mountain	House Mountain State Natural Area	30 mins	2.5	Steep	Pre-teens and older
13	Aspire Park	Aspire Park	30 mins	1.0	Moderate	Toddlers and Little kids
14	Emory Falls at Frozen Head	Frozen Head State Park	50 mins	2.4	Moderate	Little kids
15	The Obed Point Trail	Obed Wild & Scenic River	50 mins	3.6	Gentle	Little kids and Big kids
16	Bandy Creek Camp-ground	Big South Fork NRR	1 hr 30 mins	1.3	Flat	Toddlers and Little kids
17	Fall Branch Falls	Big South Fork NRR	1 hr 30 mins	3.7	Moderate	Big kids and Pre-teens and older
18	Twin Arches	Big South Fork NRR	1 hr 45 mins	1.2	Moderate	Little kids and Big kids
19	Angel Falls Overlook	Big South Fork NRR	1 hr 30 mins	2.8	Gentle	Little kids and Big kids
20	Honey Creek	Big South Fork NRR	1 hr 30 mins	4.4	Steep	Big kids and Pre-teens and older
21	Spruce Flats Falls	Great Smoky Mountains NP	50 mins	1.6	Moderate	Big kids and Pre-teens and older
22	Little River	Great Smoky Mountains NP	1 hour	5.5	Moderate	Little kids, Big kids, and Pre-teens and older
23	Mouse Creek	Great Smoky Mountains NP	1 hr 5 mins	4.0	Moderate	Little kids and Big kids

Trail #	Trail Name	Location	Time from Knoxville	Trail Distance (Mi.)	Eleva- tion	Best Ages
24	Middle Prong	Great Smoky Mountains NP	1 hr 5 mins	7.6	Mod- erate	All ages
25	Abrams Creek	Great Smoky Mountains NP	55 mins	5.8	Mod- erate	All ages
26	Look Rock	Great Smoky Mountains NP	45 mins	0.6	Mod- erate	Toddlers and Little kids
27	Chestnut Top	Great Smoky Mountains NP	45 mins	2.6	Steep	Big kids
28	Abrams Falls	Great Smoky Mountains NP	1 hr 30 mins	5.0	Steep	Big kids and Pre-teens and older
29	Andrews Bald	Great Smoky Mountains NP	1 hr 45 mins	3.6	Mod- erate	Big kids and Pre-teens and older
30	Alum Cave Bluffs	Great Smoky Mountains NP	1 hr 15 mins	4.5	Very Steep	Big kids and Pre-teens and older

Top 5 Hikes

Here are some hikes that we recommend for different reasons—and ages of kids.

For Hiking With Babies and Infants

These hikes are great when a short distance and a paved path are a priority.

1. High Ground Park
2. Knox-Blount Greenway
3. Lakeshore Park
4. UT Arboretum
5. Norris Dam

Real Hikes for Little Explorers Walking on Their Own

These are “real” hikes—you and your little will know it!—but they’re also a reasonable distance and with not-too-challenging terrain.

1. Ijams Riverside
2. Seven Islands
3. Emory Falls
4. Abrams Creek
5. Chestnut Tops

For Kids Who Need a Playground Nearby

Who doesn’t love a hike that starts and ends at or near a playground?

1. Lakeshore
2. Emory Fall
3. Ijams Riverside
4. Ijams Crag
5. Sequoyah Park

For Kids Who Love to Play in the Water

These hikes are great in warmer weather; bring the right clothing and shoes and let 'em splash!

1. Middle Prong
2. Abrams Creek
3. Spruce Flats Falls
4. Honey Creek
5. Mouse Creek

Best Spots for a Picnic

Each of these is a fantastic place to have a family picnic.

1. Mouse Creek
2. Lakeshore
3. Seven Islands
4. Sequoyah Park
5. Ijams Crag

Bigger Adventures for Bigger Kids

*More challenging hikes for kids who are ready for the next challenge; completing any of these is an achievement.

1. Alum Cave -
2. Andrews Bald -
3. Honey Creek -
4. Little River
5. Abrams Falls

Knoxville and its Surroundings

Figures included in this chapter:

- maps/Knoxville_Region_v6.jpg

Knoxville and the Tennessee Valley contain fewer high points than the Cumberland Plateau and the Great Smoky Mountains, but it should not be discounted as a destination for hiking.

We think a trip to Seven Islands State Birding Park will make evident how spectacular this area can be. Around 30 minutes away from most places in Knoxville, this is a true destination not only for birders, but also hikers and paddlers.

Other locations are also not only close, but worthy of a trip. Ijams on the south side of Knoxville—familiar to many in the Knoxville area—has many spectacular features, in addition to being fewer than ten minutes away from downtown.

Other places that we highlight among the 12 trails in this section are very worth your time, offering an outdoors respite in addition to the ability to easily be integrated into busy schedules and other commitments. If you are looking for a first family hike, those in this section may make a great selection.

Trail 1: Seven Islands

Figures included in this chapter:

- seven-islands-entrance.jpg
- trail-01-map.jpeg
- pawpaw.jpg
- kids-run.jpg

Overview

This is one of our favorite trails in this book, and it is the first trail for that reason! This hike is a crowd pleaser for every family member of all ages thanks to a paved path that makes bringing babies in a stroller a breeze and easy acces to experience meadow, woodland, and a river! For the trail we highlight, a paved path descends through a meadow. Look for varied bird varieties and deer in all seasons! The trail crosses a bridge over the French Broad River and then a dirt trail make a loop around a beautiful island before returning back to the paved path. This hike is great for all ages and seasons, though it is sometimes hot in the summer due to limited shade on the paved part of the trail.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	30 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	2.3
Elevation Change	Gentle
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	Yes
Best Ages	Toddlers, Little kids, and Big kids
Accessibility	Partially accessible (path is paved until the island portion)

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Seven Islands State Birding Park, 2809 Kelly Ln, Kodak, TN 37764

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.95366, -83.68701

Park in the large gravel lot (note there is another parking area by a boat launch that is not the correct location for this hike!). We have never had trouble finding a spot even on the busiest of days.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Access the Bobwhite Access Trail by walking around or through the barn.
0.05	Bathroom on the left of the trail.
0.1	Descend through grassy meadows with wildflowers in the spring and early fall.
0.3	Bench makes for a nice rest spot.
0.6	Start of the Newmans Island Bridge.
0.8	Paved trail ends. Turn right onto the Island Loop Trail to hike around the island. The paw paw grove is off to the left soon after you begin hiking clockwise around the island. Can you find one?
0.85	Picnic table beside a pretty part of the French Broad River.
1.05	Stick house (kiddo favorite!).
1.5	Connect back to the bridge, heading back onto the Bobwhite Access Trail.
2	Climb back up the Bobwhite Access Trail to the trailhead.
2.3	Trailhead.

i Paw Paw

A native fruit found around Seven Islands. Tastes like a mix of an apple and a banana. Paw Paw flowers are pollinated by beetles and flies.

Nearby

- **Take advantage of the other trails nearby!** Hike up the Hickory Ridge trail, another trail at Seven Islands State Birding Park, that is accessible from just behind the bathrooms

near the parking lot. There are several other great hikes available, including hikes down the Kelly Lane Greenway (the other, wider, paved path near the barn that is gated to prevent cars from driving on it) and the Upland Inner and Outer Trail Loops.

- **Bring your canoe, kayak, or paddle board for even more adventures!** Access parking by Also, River Sports Outfitters rents kayaks and canoes here during the summer (see <https://www.riversportsoutfitters.com/>).
- **Stop for a bite to eat and a drink on the way back!** Consider stopping by kid-friendly Walnut Springs Winery (1175 Midway Rd, Knoxville, TN 37914), open Wednesday-Sunday as of this writing.

Trail 2: Ijams Riverside

Figures included in this chapter:

- katie-jo-riverside.jpeg
- trail-02-map.jpeg

Overview

It's easy to take this destination for granted if you live in Knoxville – we seem to find something new every time we visit! Bring along your baby carrier for this hike, which is meant to be a gentle introduction to what Ijams refers to as the Riverside area. The trail starts by the Ijams Nature Center's visitor center and meanders down through a deep forest to the river. It continues along the boardwalk trail that happens to follow the side of the very first mile of the Tennessee River. The trail returns back up and over a rocky ridge to return to the visitor center. Ijams offers multiple play areas and links to other trails nearby, so you can make a day of it!

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	10-15 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	1.05
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required (pay on site)
Restroom(s)	Yes
Best Ages	mToddlers and Little Kids
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Ijams Nature Center, 2915 Island Home Ave, Knoxville, TN 37920

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.95612, -83.86725

Use the above address to easily navigate to the parking area. Park in the large parking lot near the Visitor's Center.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start near the doors to the Visitor's Center and access the trail via the wooden steps.
0.05	Turn left to begin the North Cove Trail.
0.2	Turn right onto the River Trail.
0.4	Short wooden stairs down to the boardwalk section.
0.5	End of the boardwalk section.
0.6	Climb rock steps.
0.7	Turn right on the Tower Trail (or, optionally, remain on the River Trail to head toward Mead's Quarry).
0.85	Pass an old communication tower at the high point of the trail; begin to descend back to the Visitor's Center.
1.03	Return to the Visitor's Center.

Blue Phlox

Blue Phlox is a native wildflower that blooms in early to mid-spring. These plants provide an important source of early-season nectar for pollinators, like the swallowtail butterfly and other native moths. -MaryRose Weatherton

Nearby

- **Visiting Jo's Grove near the Visitor's Center.** This area which features a fun cabin and a wooded area for kids to play (this is a premiere hide-and-seek spot!**)
- **Grabbing a bite to eat on the south side of Knoxville!** Our favorites include South Coast Pizza (1103 Sevier Ave, Knoxville, TN 37920) and Angry Dumplings Tea (1119 Sevier Ave, Knoxville, TN 37920). Breweries nearby also abound, as well as Suttree Landing Park, which boasts a very fun playground.

- **Seeing more of what Ijams has to offer.** Check by checking out the Ijams Crag hike across the road at Mead' Quarry!

Trail 3: Lakeshore Park

Figures included in this chapter:

- lakeshore-new-edited.jpeg
- trail-03-map.jpeg
- huie.jpg
- lakeshore sled.jpg

Overview

A gem in Knoxville's city park system, this hike, entirely on a paved path, circles the perimeter of the park, featuring high points, views of the Smokies, and a boardwalk along the river. It also boasts four excellent play areas along the way! Well known, but not overrated, this is a great spot for a hike that could fit into a busy weekend, or even a weeknight, and is great for young ones of all ages, truly offering something for everyone.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	10-15 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	2.2
Elevation Change	Gentle
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	Yes
Best Ages	Toddlers, Little Kids, and Big Kids
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Lakeshore Park, 6014 Lyons View Pike, Knoxville, TN 37919

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.92389, -83.990

The address above navigates to the park's main entrance. Our hike starts at a large parking area near the center of the park. To find it, entering Lakeshore from Lyons View Pike, turn onto Cliffside Dr. and park in the large parking area on the right, immediately past Circle Dr. Start on the greenway near the parking lot on the same side of the road on which you are parked. Of course, you can park elsewhere nearby or in any parking area at Lakeshore.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Cross Orchard Drive, heading clockwise on the paved greenway. Note the greenway on the left, which immediately heads toward the Huie Woodland Playground.
0.05	Bench and overlook to the Smokies. Can you spy Clingman's Dome? Note that Hank Rappé playground is immediately below the greenway (to your right).
0.15	Short, steep descent!
0.4	Optional boardwalk section (recommended!). Check out the viewing platform overlooking the Tennessee River around 200 feet ahead on the left.
0.5	Boardwalk and the primary greenway reconnect.
0.9	Central Playground on the right.
1.2	Tower Playground on the right.
1.5	Ascent (followed by a little hill back down) begins.
2.2	Traihead.

i Appalachian Trail

Surprisingly, the crest of the Smokies (and the Appalachian Trail) are visible from this park. The Appalachian Trail is more than 2,100 miles long, beginning at Springer Mountain, Georgia, and ending at Mount Katahdin, in Maine. The longest section without a road crossing is in the Smokies – from Fontana Dam to Newfound Gap.

Nearby

- **Enjoy one or more of the many playgrounds!** There are four awesome playgrounds at Lakeshore: Hank Rappé (universal playground with a bit of everything), Huie Woodland (nature-themed), Tower (lots of climbing opportunities, best for kids age 5 and older), and Central (best suited for ages 5 and older, and with workout equipment nearby for adults).

- **Bring a picnic!** Lakeshore seems made for picnics. Enjoy one on a grassy area or one of numerous seating areas near the Hank Rappé, Tower, and Central playgrounds.

Trail 4: High Ground Park

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-04-figure-01.jpg
- trail-04-map.jpeg

Overview

This is one of the closest hikes to the city center of Knoxville, and it's stroller-friendly! This short but sweet hike is perfect as a real but accessible outing for toddlers and little kids. The red chairs at the top are a fun stopping point. The deep woods are pretty and offer something new in each season. This could be a great first hike for toddlers – it was one of the first for our little one, and made us feel like we could start venturing to other regional hiking destinations.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	10-15 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	0.7
Elevation Change	Gentle
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Toddlers and Little kids
Accessibility	Accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: High Ground Park, 1000 Cherokee Trail, Knoxville, TN 37920

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.93824, -83.9258

The trail begins from the parking lot at the above address; look for the paved path near the back of the parking lot. You can't miss it!

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0	Start off on the trail with a gentle descent.
0.1	Enter the wooded part of the hike and begin a gentle climb.
0.35	Red chairs and the large open area. Head toward the mowed grassy section.
0.4	Look for a spur trail that heads to the site of the Fort Higley earthworks, constructed during the Civil War by Union forces.
0.7	Traihead.

Nearby

- **Stop by a fun food hall before or after!** The nearby Kern's Food Hall (2201 Kerns Rising Way, Knoxville, TN 37920) has a good range of options and an outdoor play area for kids to romp around.
- **For more outdoor fun, hike the nearby River Bluff Wildlife area.** The nearby River Bluff Wildlife Area is an interesting counterbalance to the ease of High Ground Park. it features a short but rustic hike to a pretty overlook of the city.**** Visit Knoxville's website (<https://www.visitknoxville.com/>) has more information and a nice map.

Trail 5: UT Arboretum

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-05-figure-01.jpg
- trail-05-map.jpeg
- second ut arboretum.jpg
- bluebird.PNG

Overview

This is a gem of a hike that is off the radar for many in Knoxville, as it is tucked away in nearby Oak Ridge. Start your hike at a trailhead that offers many hiking options. We recommend walking up the paved path past botanical specimens, including “unique conifers”! Circle around park facilities past a pretty field and forests. Upon returning to the start, there are other trails to the different ecological zones represented in an area that is worth a visit; we like the trails near the marshy area with the clear creek, perfect for splashing in warm weather. Suitable for kids of all ages.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	25-30 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	0.9
Elevation Change	Gentle
Pets	Not Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Toddlers and Little Kids
Accessibility	Accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: University of Tennessee Arboretum, 901 S Illinois Ave, Oak Ridge, TN 37830

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.99392, -84.21988

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Walk along the paved road.
0.1	Start of the Oak-Hickory Trail on the right.
0.2	Start of the Heath Cove Trail on the left. This is a shortcut if you're looking for one!
0.3	Wind around, still on the road.
0.5	Shelter on the right.
0.6	Auditorium on the right.
0.7	Leave the paved road for a short dirt path called Evans Way Trail. Alternatively, turn around and head back on the paved path.
0.9	Trailhead.

i Eastern Bluebird

While many birds stop over at Seven Islands and areas like that on their migratory routes south (in the fall) and north (in the spring), the Eastern Bluebird is a year-round resident. Bluebirds are obligate cavity nesters - which is why they have experienced such a decline in their population as urban sprawl has increased. Refuges like Seven Islands give them lots of opportunities to find natural cavities to nest in! -MaryRose Weatherton

Nearby

- **Explore some of the many other trails nearby.** The trail we featured meanders through a very small section of a large, diverse park. The Nature Book Trail is a great trail to add on to your hike. There are many others; check out the map at the UT Arboretum website (<https://utarboretum.tennessee.edu/>) to learn more.

- **Bring the balance bikes and kids' bikes and stop by Haw Ridge and its kids' pump track.** Nearby Haw Ridge Park features the Dirtlab Mountain Bike Skill Park, a great spot for kids riding balance bikes and pedal bikes to hone their skills and build confidence!

Trail 6: Knox-Blount Greenway

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-06-figure-01.jpg
- trail-06-map.jpeg

Overview

Another hike that is very close to Knoxville's city center, the Knox-Blount Greenway, is a fun, easier outing for little walkers, bikers, and for parents pushing little ones in strollers. Paved throughout, this trail offers a glimpse of the surprising beauty of the Tennessee River so close to the city. Our description features a route that heads to the north, toward the city, and then back to the trail from the research park further south, before returning to the start. Look for blue herons and other birds along the side of the river; you might see a Bald Eagle! While beautiful, there is limited shade here, so factor the weather in before setting out to this destination! This will be a fun hike for a gaggle of kids looking to toddle or run wild!

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	5-10 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	2.3
Elevation Change	Gentle
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Toddlers and Little Kids
Accessibility	Accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: University of Tennessee Research Park at Cherokee Farm, 2641 Osprey Vista Way, Knoxville, TN 37920

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.94191, -83.95270

Park in the lot at the above address. If helpful, the building next to the lot is the IAM Electron Microscopy Facility. The start of the trail is at the top of a terraced amphitheater—conveniently, one that’s easy to walk down.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Walk down the terraced amphitheater.
0.1	Begin to descend down a gradual hill.
0.3	Reach the river and the Knox-Blount Greenway trail proper. Our route turns right, but you can explore in either direction!
0.35	Follow the greenway along the river. The meadows to the right are usually mowed; kids may like to cruise through them!
0.8	Our preferred route turns around at the intersection of the greenway and a spur trail. Of course, you can continue further if you like. Head back the other direction
1.3	Pass the trail from the amphitheater you took earlier, continuing along the river.
1.65	Turn around at the intersection of another spur trail.
2.0	Meet back up with the trail to the amphitheater.
2.3	Trailhead.

Bald Eagle

Common along local rivers, including the river beside this hike—the Tennessee River. You may even spot a nesting pair on nearby Looney Island.

Nearby

- **Take time to visit the UT Gardens.** The nearby UT Gardens (2621 Morgan Circle, Knoxville, TN 37996) is a great spot for a meander through beautiful gardens. Be sure to check out the Children’s Garden featuring grassy mounds and ample play structures!

- **Bike the greenways!** While we featured the Knox-Blount Greenway as a hike, it's also a fun bike ride for young bikers.

Trail 7: Sequoyah Park

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-07-figure-01.jpg
- trail-07-map.jpeg
- elm.png
- trail-07-figure-02.jpg

Overview

This is another gem among Knoxville city parks, nestled in the heart of the the city in a neighborhood. The trail starts at a large parking area near the restroom building and walks towards the river. It follows the river past open fields, trees, and bushes which playfully beckon for kids not to explore! The trail cuts up toward the greenway and hikes past Indian burial mounds and the historic homes along the path before returning to the start. In mild weather, it is a fantastic spot to hang up a hammock, fish, have a picnic, or toss a frisbee or a football. This outing is ideal for kids of all walking ages, and alternate ways to access the greenway make it easy to create a shorter loop.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	10-15 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	2.1
Elevation Change	Flat
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	Yes
Best Ages	Toddlers and Little Kids
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Sequoyah Park Restrooms, W2HG+M9, Knoxville, TN 37919

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.92932, -83.97398

The above address takes you to the parking area next to restrooms that serve as a landmark for this sprawling park. Please note that the address uses a Google Maps Plus code, as this location does not have a street address.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Walk southwest (toward the large, open part of the park) along the river.
0.1	Kayak and canoe put in spot on the right.
0.25	Enter a wooded section.
0.4	Bench.
0.65	Distinctive, dome-shaded trees that kids can crawl into, between, and through.
0.9	Small rocky hill to walk over (you can walk around it on the greenway, but kids may enjoy scrambling up it).
1.1	Boat launch. Head up beside or through the parking lot to Sequoyah Greenway in the center of Cherokee Blvd. Turn left onto the greenway.
1.2	Site of Native American mound. Note the historical marker. Walk along past the homes on both sides of the greenway.
2.05	Trailhead.

i Elm Tree

Trees characterized by an umbrella-shaped crown. The tree near the start of this hike (surrounded by a wire enclosure to prevent cars from being parked nearby) is known as a "Champion" of its kind – the largest Elm in Knoxville."

i Native American Mounds

These earthen mounds are found in many places along the Mississippi River and its tributaries—like the Tennessee River. Nobody is completely sure why they were built, but some believe they served as gathering spots or markers to return to time and again. The mound here may date back as early as the 1400s, likely created by one of the Native Nations with ancestral ties to the Knoxville region.

Nearby

- **Grab a coffee, baked good, or breakfast!** Nearby Treetop Coffee Shop (1206 Kenesaw Ave, Knoxville, TN 37919) and The Plaid Apron restaurant (1210 Kenesaw Ave, Knoxville, TN 37919) next door are great places to stop by. Check their hours of operation before visiting!
- **Explore a bit more of the neighborhood!** Nearby Whitlow Park (4228 Whitlow Ave SW, Knoxville, TN 37919) features a small but fun playground, nice tennis courts, and a basketball court.

Trail 8: Ijams Crag

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-08-figure-01.jpg
- trail-08-map.jpeg
- ijams marble callout.jpeg

Overview

This trail is a nice introduction to the area of Ijams that is centered around Mead's Quarry, which Ijams refers to as the Quarryside area. The hike begins at the quarry and winds up a smooth then rocky trail. The overlook is for Ijams Crag, a popular outdoor rock climbing area. We love having a snack at the shade of the pine trees at the overlook. After winding back to the start, be sure to explore one of the two excellent nature play areas nearby or take a side trail back to extend the trip. This area offers something for all ages, but the hike itself is best suited to young hikers who are able to navigate steeper, rocky terrain. Younger hikers will need assistance.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	10-15 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	1.5
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required (pay on site).
Restroom(s)	Yes
Best Ages	Little Kids and Big Kids
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Meads Quarry, 3526 Island Home Ave, Knoxville, TN 37920

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.95174, -83.86587

Park in the parking lot for Meads Quarry using the above address. The trail begins alongside the disused railroad tracks; look for a sign for Imery's Trail.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on Imery's trail, heading away from the parking lot.
0.15	Gradually, then more steeply, begin to ascend.
0.30	Trail levels out at an intersection between Imery's Trail, Rock Bridge Trail, and Gravel Road Trail.
0.5	Rocky and steep.
0.75	Reach the overlook to Ijams Quarry. Rest up, and then turn around to head back, or continue farther along on Imery's!
1.50	Trailhead.

Tennessee Marble

Mead's Quarry—near the parking area now filled with crystal clear water—was a quarry for what was called Tennessee Marble". Geologically

Nearby

- **Make sure to stop by the Ijams Visitor Center for a unique gift shop and a small collection of local river-based animals!** Check out the Ijams River and Tower loop for an introduction to this other area of the Ijams Nature Center.
- **Play at the Ijams Nature Playscape.** This is an amazing part of Ijams, worthy of a visit on its own. Tucked away a bit on the side of the parking area at Mead's Quarry. It's a favorite for kids, with a treehouse, tightrope, stumps for jumping, and, yes, a mud pit!
- **Check out the Ijams Primal playground.** Also nearby, smaller than the Nature Playground, but packed with features for climbing and jumping for kids able to climb and explore with little adult assistance.

Trail 9: William Hastie

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-09-figure-01.jpg
- trail-09-map.jpeg
- turtle.png

Overview

You'll be surrounded by trees galore at William Hastie! The start features a beginner's mountain bike loop on a smooth path. Though short, this hike takes you by many spur trails; consider this a gentle introduction to a trail system close to but more rustic than Ijams. Good for all toddling and walking kids and their families.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	15 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	1.3
Elevation Change	Flat
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Toddlers and little kids
Accessibility	Partially accessible (graded gravel path)

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: William Hastie Natural Area, 1302 Margaret Rd, Knoxville, TN 37920

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.93464, -83.87455

The above address will direct you to a large, rarely-busy parking lot and a nice trailhead with a picnic area. Several trails start from this trailhead. Look for a sign for the Margaret Road Trail.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on the Margaret Road Trail.
0.2	Small pond on the right. Look for turtles!
0.25	Shadow Run Trail on the right.
0.65	Reach the Post Oak Ln. Trailhead and turn around.
1.30	Trailhead.

Eastern Box Turtle

Box turtles have the unique ability to completely hide in their shells due to a hinged plastron. They are long lived reptiles that can live over 120 years. They have extraordinary memories and are able to know exactly where they are due to an internal map (which is why you should never relocate them). Their populations have been hurt by illegal pet trade. - Alex Edwards

Nearby

- **Bring a bike and enjoy the kids' loop.** The “green” mountain biking trail near the start (it's called “Springarn”) is a great spot for kids to begin to learn to ride on trails. It's only 0.6 miles and is a nice complement to this hike.
- **Explore some of the many other trails while you're there.** William Hastie Natural Area features many other trails of varying difficulty. Consider taking Mitchie's Way from near the parking area—and then looping back to Margaret Road and the start on the trail of your choice.

Trail 10: Sharp's Ridge

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-10-figure-01.jpg
- trail-10-map.jpeg
- lichenwithlabels.png
- sharps-trail.jpg

Overview

This hike is just north of downtown, making it a great stop before grabbing a bite to eat at a nearby restaurant or heading downtown. Wind up from the trailhead on a smooth path through the pretty forest. When we think of this trail, we think of little ones toddling or running ahead around the bends in the trail, just far enough to be out of sight for a little bit until we catch up! Once you connect to the road, consider walking up to an overlook with lovely view of the Smokies. Best for older kids or younger kids who are carried in a carrier or backpack.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	10 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	2.3
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Little kids
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Sharps Ridge Trailhead, 599-501 Ridge Ave, Knoxville, TN 37917

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 36.00344, -83.93787

The trailhead can be just a little tricky to find—partially because Google Maps has several trailheads with the same name! We once met friends at different Sharps Ridge Trailheads! Consider putting in the address (above) to find the trailhead, which is at the end of Hanover St. Park in one of the parking spots or the gravel area on the side of Ridge Ave.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start by walking through the Arbor, past the trail map of the Sharps Ridge area. You're technically on the very short Hanover Access trail.
0.1	Turn right onto Lincoln Trail. Wind up through the deep woods and easy curves in the trail.
0.8	Turn right onto Sharp Shin.
0.9	Meet Sharps Ridge Memorial Park Drive. Turn left to walk along the side of the road toward the overlook, or, alternatively, head back to the start!
1.15	Overlook. See if you can spy the Sunsphere, Neyland Stadium, and the Smokies in the distance. Turn around to head back the way you came.
1.4	Turn right, back onto Sharp Shin.
1.5	Turn left onto Lincoln Trail.
2.2	Turn left onto the Hanover Access Trail.
2.3	Trailhead.

Lichen

There are three primary types of lichens: Foliose (leaf-like in appearance), Crustose (crusty looking), and Fruiticose (coral-like and bushy). They are abundant in the region and are great bioindicators of air quality! -Amanda Garner

Nearby

- **Grab a bite to eat at a nearby restaurant.** Favorite nearby spots include the fantastic Wild Love Bakehouse (1625 N Central St, Knoxville, TN 37917), the quick,

inexpensive, tasty Taqueria La Herradura (2625 N Broadway, Knoxville, TN 37917), and Hard Knox Pizza Central (2300 N Central St, Knoxville, TN 37917).

- **Hike further or on other trails to keep the adventures rolling.** Sharp's Ridge includes many other trails. A favorite starts at a different nearby parking area, immediately behind the Cherry Creek Apartments (navigate to 3404 Dill St, Knoxville, TN 37917). We like the Lincoln Trail, which is also an accessible mountain bike trail.

Trail 11: Norris Dam

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-11-figure-01.jpg
- trail-11-map.jpeg
- norris-dam.jpg

Overview

If you're looking for a trail that youngest walkers can succeed it, head north of Knoxville about 30 minutes and check out the Songbird trail at Norris Dam State Park. Further, it's on a graded gravel path. Like the Knox-Blount Greenway along the Tennessee River. You may be surprised by the variety and quantity of wildlife you see along the scenic Clinch River, which this hike invites you to enjoy as you stroll. This is a relaxing trail for a family outing that might end with a drive over Norris Dam or a stop for a bite and a drink at the nearby Clinch River Brewery. On warmer days, you'll enjoy cooler temps at this riverside trail due to its location in the valley near water. For toddlers who are no longer happy in a stroller or backpack carrier, this hike would be a fun and rewarding challenge!

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	30 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	2.3
Elevation Change	Gentle
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Little kids and Big kids
Accessibility	Partially accessible (graded gravel path)

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Canoe Ramp by the Songbird Loop, 6W6G+R7 Rocky Top, Tennessee

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 36.21210, -84.07397

There are several possible trailheads. We chose to start this hike from a put in spot for kayaks and canoes. In Google Maps, you can search the above address. Please note it uses a “Plus code” instead of a street address, as the canoe ramp does not have an address. This is immediately off Norris Fwy. (Highway 441).

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Cross a short bridge over Clear Creek.
0.05	Turn right (though, it is a loop and you may choose to go the other other way).
0.3	Cross a short bridge.
1.0	Turn left, toward the river, remaining on the same trail.
1.05	Follow the trail back along the river.
2.3	Trailhead.

Norris Dam

This was the first dam built by the Tennessee Valley Authority (TVA), completed in 1936. It is 265 feet high and a little more than 1,800 feet wide. Behind it lies Norris Lake, a favorite for paddling and boating, while the Clinch River flows just below.

Nearby

- **Grab a bite and a drink Clinch River Brewery.** Clinch River Brewing (2045 Norris Fwy, Norris, TN 37828) is not within the boundaries of the Norris Dam State Park—but it’s very close to the trailhead and is a fun place to stop for lunch or dinner before or after a hike.
- **Check out the Norris Dam, which has been in operation since the mid-1930s.** Stop at the TVA Norris Dam Visitor Center on the same side of the Clinch River as this hike—or drive across and back over the dam for an impressive, even otherworldly experience!

Trail 12: House Mountain

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-12-figure-01.jpg
- trail-12-map.jpeg
- trail-12-figure-02.jpg

Overview

This hike is not for the faint of heart! Perhaps this comes as a surprise given its proximity to Knoxville, but this hike features significant elevation change, rocky and uneven terrain, and even sections where it is unclear where precisely the trail goes. If you have littles that need to be carried, we recommend waiting to tackle this hike (Katie carried our oldest in a baby carrier up this hike when he was a baby and will honestly tell you she doesn't have fond memories of this hike). This one always challenges us, but the flip side is that House Mountain offers a hike that is very rewarding and challenging hike closer to home than you would expect. The trail climbs up House Mountain from the west, reaching the West Overlook before heading down to complete the loop.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	30 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	2.5
Elevation Change	Steep
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Pre-teens and older
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: House Mountain Parking and Trailhead, 463P+WV Corryton, Tennessee

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 36.10483, -83.76276

Park at the large parking area and look for the large covered picnic area. The Connector Trail near the picnic area is where you'll begin the hike.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on the Connector Trail.
0.1	Turn left onto the West Overlook Trail and begin your ascent.
0.85	Rocky prominence. The trail changes here to the Crest Trail and flattens.
1.25	Reach the West Overlook. Continue on the Crest Trail. Optionally, this is a suitable turn-around spot.
1.6	Intersection with the East Overlook Trail. Turn right.
1.7	Steep descent.
2.0	Trail levels out, and the descent becomes more gradual and winding.
2.3	Trailhead.

Pine Trees

A family of conifers recognizable by their needles, which usually grow in bundles, and their seeds, which develop in stiff cones—making them distinct from hemlocks, spruces, and firs. Look for pines as you hike up to the ridge.

Nearby

- **Spend some time at Zoo Knoxville on the way home.** Zoo Knoxville (3500 Knoxville Zoo Dr, Knoxville, TN 37914) is accessible from I-40, on the way to House Mountain for those traveling from Knoxville or west of the city center, is a fantastic place to spend half a day (or longer)! It is one of our family's favorite spots.

Trail 13: Aspire Park

Figures included in this chapter:

- maps/Aspire_v2.jpg

Overview

If you're looking for a trail that youngest walkers can succeed it, head north of Knoxville about 30 minutes and check out the Songbird trail at Norris Dam State Park. Further, it's on a graded gravel path. Like the Knox-Blount Greenway along the Tennessee River. You may be surprised by the variety and quantity of wildlife you see along the scenic Clinch River, which this hike invites you to enjoy as you stroll. This is a relaxing trail for a family outing that might end with a drive over Norris Dam or a stop for a bite and a drink at the nearby Clinch River Brewery. On warmer days, you'll enjoy cooler temps at this riverside trail due to its location in the valley near water. For toddlers who are no longer happy in a stroller or backpack carrier, this hike would be a fun and rewarding challenge!

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	30 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	1.0
Elevation Change	Moderate (flat with one steep section)
Pets	Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Toddlers and Little kids
Accessibility	Accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Canoe Ramp by the Songbird Loop, 6W6G+R7 Rocky Top, Tennessee

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 36.21210, -84.07397

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Cross a short bridge over Clear Creek.
0.05	Turn right (though, it is a loop and you may choose to go the other other way).
0.3	Cross a short bridge.
1.0	Turn left, toward the river, remaining on the same trail.
1.05	Follow the trail back along the river.
2.3	Trailhead.

Nearby

- **Grab a bite and a drink Clinch River Brewery.** Clinch River Brewing (2045 Norris Fwy, Norris, TN 37828) is not within the boundaries of the Norris Dam State Park—but it's very close to the trailhead and is a fun place to stop for lunch or dinner before or after a hike.
- **Check out the Norris Dam, which has been in operation since the mid-1930s.** Stop at the TVA Norris Dam Visitor Center on the same side of the Clinch River as this hike—or drive across and back over the dam for an impressive, even otherworldly experience!

The Cumberland Plateau

Figures included in this chapter:

- maps/Plateau_Region_v6.jpg

This region is the hidden gem near Knoxville. It's a plateau, with valleys carved out by rivers through the softer sandstone rock that is common in this area. There are also parts that are quite mountainous, particularly near Frozen Head State Park.

The defining characteristic of the Cumberland Plateau is its geology: incredible rock features and rock houses. You'll see rock formations small and (strikingly) large on all of your hikes in the plateau. Some will amaze you that they (and you) are in East Tennessee.

Something not very widely-recognized is that one of the most well-known hikers in American history, John Muir took his first extended hike through this area. The second chapter of *A Thousand-Mile Walk to the Gulf*, a book published after his death based on his diaries, describes his crossing of the Cumberland Mountains. Describing the Emory River, he wrote, "There is nothing more eloquent in Nature than a mountain stream, and this is the first I ever saw." He continued, "This is the most primitive county I have seen, primitive in everything. The remotest hidden parts of Wisconsin are far in advance of the mountain regions of Tennessee and North Carolina." He concludes with a description from an overlook, "The scenery is far grander than any I ever before beheld. The view extends from the Cumberland Mountains on the north far into Georgia and North Carolina to the south, an area of about five thousand square miles. Such an ocean of wooded, waving, swelling mountain beauty and grandeur is not to be described." One trail in this section is along part of the John Muir Trail. Like him, you may be surprised by how primitive and beautiful this area is.

These seven hikes are some of the most special to us in this book; a little off-the-radar and even underappreciated, part of our motivation for writing this book was to draw attention to them.

Trail 14: Emory Falls at Frozen Head

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-14-figure-01.jpg
- trail-14-map.jpeg
- cliffs-emory.jpg

Overview

Writing about this trail makes us smile. In many ways, it's the perfect kid hike! It starts at a beautiful trailhead along a pretty creek in the deep woods. It gradually climbs before stopping at one of two scenic waterfall, DeBord Falls, and is a perfectly acceptable place to turn around with younger kids (we have many times!). It continues further to Emory Falls before returning on a gradual slope back to the trailhead. Stop at the playground you passed on the way to the trailhead beside the same creek; the water is usually shallow enough to be perfect for splashing and rock hopping. Please note, the trail is rocky, and your kids will likely need reminders to slow down!

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	50 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	2.4
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking	Not Required
Pass/Entrance Fee	
Restroom(s)	No restrooms at the trailhead parking, but you will pass restrooms on the right about three quarters of a mile before the trailhead parking area.
Best Ages	Little kids
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Emory Gap Trailhead, 4GP6+MV, Wartburg, TN 37887

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 36.13658, -84.48785

Park at the Emory Gap Trailhead. Note that the above address uses a “Plus code” that will only work in Google Maps—because Emory Gap Trailhead does not have a street address.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start by walking across the bridge at the trailhead.
0.55	DeBord Falls. Walk down the (steep!) stairs on the right to view the waterfall from below. Optional turnaround spot.
0.9	Trail switchbacks.
1.1	Steep and rocky section at the end to the viewing spot for Emory Falls.
1.2	After viewing the waterfall, head back to the start!
2.4	Trailhead.

i Brushy Mountain State Penitentiary

A closed prison near Frozen Head State Park is full of lore due to its remote location. Part of the inspiration for the Barkley Marathons (you’ll have to look it up). Now the site of a restaurant and distillery.

Nearby

- **Enjoy the playground!** There is a fun, shaded creekside playground 0.7 miles down the road from the trailhead. Most of the year, the creek is a perfect depth for safe splashing.
- **Check out the Flat Fork Story Book Trail.** Starting near the playground, this short trail is great for the littlest hikers.
- **Hike to the Frozen Head Mountain Summit.** A challenge for the biggest kid hikers and adults! This hike is around seven strenuous miles to and back from the Lookout Tower at the summit of Frozen Head Mountain, from which views of the Smokies far in the distance can be faintly visible on clear days.

Trail 15: Obed Point Trail

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-15-figure-01.jpg
- trail-15-map.jpeg
- bigleaf-magnolia.jpg

Overview

Just far enough to be off the radar of many in Knoxville, this trail has a bit of everything - fun bridge crossings, deep forest, waterfalls, and two pretty overlooks. It does not climb so much as to become tiresome, but it's long enough to feel like a real adventure. There's something about the Obed area that feels both wild and inviting. The only downside? It's a little out-of-the-way; in some ways, this trail feels farther than some destinations in the Smokies. It's worth it for a great family hike with kids of all ages. Though out of the way, there are a few fun things to do to extend the hike or to visit very nearby on the way home. Great for kids of all hiking ages, and not a bad hike on which to carry a little one.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	50 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	3.6
Elevation Change	Gentle
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	Yes
Best Ages	Little kids and Big kids
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Lilly Bluff Trailhead, 1 Lilly Bluff Trail Head, Lansing, TN 37770

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 36.10239, -84.72183

The above address should easily navigate you to the large parking area with a restroom. Look for the sign for the point trail.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on the Point Trail.
0.15	Side trail to the Lilly Bluff Overlook for Clear Creek (we recommend!).
0.4	Small bridge crossing.
0.45	Large boulders and a rock wall. The trail winds around the side and atop the back of the wall.
0.5	Trail flattens and winds along the side of a ridge.
1	Trail bends to the right.
1.4	Trail bends to the left.
1.8	Overlook of the juncture of Clear Creek and Obed River. There are many great spots to view the rivers! After a good rest, turn around and head back to the trailhead.
3.6	Trailhead.

i Timber Rattlesnake

The Timber rattlesnake is the most venomous snake in Tennessee. Though potentially dangerous, this species is reclusive, shy, and would rather hide using its amazing camouflage pattern. They are our largest venomous snake sometimes exceeding 6 ft. in length. Like copperheads they also have heat sensing pits. They are identifiable by their rattle and chevron pattern. - Alex Edwards

Nearby

- Hang out at Lilly Pad Hopyard Brewery, only open Saturdays and Sundays, 12-6 p.m. The Lilly Pad Hopyard Brewery (<https://www.lillypadhopyardbrewery.com>) is a surprising, fantastic, kid-friendly destination for food and drinks.

- Play around the bouldering area. The Trailhead features a nearby shaded area full of boulders. While we've often used this spot as a peaceful place to finish kiddo naps, older kids love trying to climb the boulders.

Trail 16: Bandy Creek Campground

Figures included in this chapter:

- jo-bandy.jpg
- trail-16-map.jpeg

Overview

A welcoming, gentle introduction to the Big South Fork. This hike pairs best with a stay at the campground or if you're hiking the nearby Angel Falls Trail or the Fall Branch Falls trails. This happens to be the flattest trail in the book. While short, it's almost entirely on a dirt path, making it a great hike for toddlers or little kids – or parents carrying babies in a carrier.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	1 hr 30 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	1.3
Elevation Change	Flat
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking	Not Required
Pass/Entrance Fee	
Restroom(s)	Yes
Best Ages	Toddlers and Little kids
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Bandy Creek Visitors Center, 151 Stable Rd, Oneida, TN 37841

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 36.49062, -84.69777

The trailhead address will navigate you to the nearby Visitors Center (worth a visit when open (9:00 am - 5:00 pm year-round!). From the Visitors Center, look for the signs for the Bandy Creek Loop to begin the hike.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on the Bandy Loop Trail. Wind gradually toward the horse stables.
0.15	Pass the horse stables on the right. There's an easy connector trail to them near the end of the loop.
1.15	Connector trail to the horse stables.
1.3	Return to the parking area and trailhead.

NOTE - we probably want to add another photo to this chapter, and/or replace the current photo – we think this one isn't actually at Bandy Creek!

Nearby

- **Enjoy a visit at the horse stables.** Kids will likely love the nearby stables that often house many horses – most from guests at the campground who will ride the nearby horse-friendly trails. The nearby Bandy Creek Loop trail is also a good, short hike for young kiddos.
- **Camp at Bandy Creek.** This is a large, modern, scenic campground, very much worth a visit, though it is off-the-radar of many. You can almost always find a spot here—even on holiday weekends.
- **Hike the Fall Branch Falls or Angel Falls trails.** See those chapters for more details.

Trail 17: Fall Branch Falls

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-17-figure-01.jpg
- trail-17-map.jpeg
- bigleaf-magnolia.jpeg

Overview

This hike is a perfect counterbalance to the wonderful but far more familiar Great Smoky Mountains National Park. This hike, like the Big South Fork, is quieter and subtler than the Smokies. It features unique rock cliffs that are perfect for kids to take in and explore. The visitor center, horse stables (not to mention hundreds of miles of nearby trails), complement the hike. Because you can turn around at any point, this hike is great for kids of nearly any age. However, be aware of the ladders along the hike that can be a little tricky for the youngest kids to navigate!

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	1 hr 30 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	3.7
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	Yes
Best Ages	Big kids and Pre-teens and older
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Bandy Creek Visitors Center, 151 Stable Rd, Oneida, TN 37841

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 36.49062, -84.69777

From the Visitors Center, walk across Bandy Loop Road toward the campground. Find Duncan Hollow Road, and walk up it a short distance, passing the Bandy Creek Pool, which is another accessible parking area, on the left. The trailhead is immediately past the pool on the right side of Duncan Hollow Road.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on the Litten-Slaven Farm Loop Trail.
0.2	Begin to gradually descend into the Fall Branch creekbed.
0.5	Trail levels out.
0.55	Rocky section featuring a short ladder (to make it easier to navigate through the rocks).
1.8	Fall Branch Falls. A great spot for a break before turning around to return to the start.
3.6	Trailhead.

NOTE - we probably want to add another photo to this chapter, and/or replace the stock photo

i Bigleaf Magnolia

This tree has the largest simple leaf of any North American tree—one single, undivided leaf! In the fall, its leaves scatter across the ground like pages from a newspaper. You'll find it common on the Cumberland Plateau, though it's rare in the Smokies. Search for their large leaves along this trail.

Nearby

- **Camp at Bandy Creek!** The Bandy Creek Campground is a gem - spacious sites, nice restrooms, and lots of cul-de-sacs for kids to endlessly play or bike. Consider a stay here as a launching point for this hike.

- **Stop by the visitor's center.** A good place to learn more about the Big South Fork and to ask any questions or to seek the advice of park rangers.
- **Hike the nearby Bandy Creek or Angel Falls Trails.** Check out the Bandy Creek or Angel Falls Trails chapters. There are hundreds of hikes available to you, and any are well worth a hike (the Grand Gap Loop is a lengthy favorite!). Consider stopping the the visitor center to ask for recommendations and up-to-date information.

Trail 18: Twin Arches

Figures included in this chapter:

- twin arches jess.jpeg
- trail-18-map.jpeg
- trail twin arches.jpg

Overview

This short hike leads to one of the most surprising geologic features in Tennessee! The Twin Arches, a 130-foot span and 100-foot height feature you can walk over, around, and through. The surrounding forest is not shabby, either. This is a fantastic and memorable family hike, with some challenges sprinkled in. First, this hike is the farthest (by driving distance) of any in this book. Second, there are some rocky sections that require some carefulness. Still, this is a must-see, and it's near many features (and places to camp) to make a visit more accommodating. Good for families with children of any walking age.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	1 hr 45 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	1.2
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	Yes
Best Ages	Little kids and Big kids
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Twin Arches Trailhead, G7V5+Q7 Jamestown, Tennessee

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 36.48797, -84.69744

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on the Twin Arches trail.
0.25	Intersection. Head right to complete the loop in a counterclockwise section.
0.3	Stairs.
0.5	Arrive at the base of the Twin Arches. Head straight - you won't be able to miss them!
0.6	Twin Arches. Walk along the top of the arches, under them, and around them, and then head back toward the loop portion of the trail.
0.7	Turn right at the intersection to complete the loop.
0.95	Intersection. Turn right to return to the trailhead.
1.20	Trailhead.

Eastern Copperhead

The copperhead is our most common of Tennessee's venomous snakes. It is a pit viper, which means it has an external organ (pits) that allow it to see the heat signatures of its prey. This along with its fantastic camouflage makes this a great ambush predator. Identifiable by its "Hershey kiss" pattern. - Alex Edwards

Nearby

- **Camp or rent a cabin at Pickett State Park.** Pickett State Park (4605 Pickett Park Hwy, Jamestown, TN 38556), a nice campground that also has both historic and modern cabins to rent, is close to this trail. It also features a great lake for kayaking, canoeing, or paddle boarding.
- **View the night sky.** Pickett State Park has a Silver-tier designation as an International Dark Sky Park. Even if you're not strictly in the State Park, this is a great place to view stars and planets in the night sky.

Trail 19: Angel Falls Overlook

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-19-figure-01.jpg
- trail-19-map.jpeg
- angel-rocks.jpg

Overview

Like a few of the other trails in or near the Cumberland Plateau, this is a spectacular hike that is sadly often overlooked. While this memorable trail is a little tricky to get to for a day hike, the view is awesome, rivaling the summits of the Smokies, with a different kind of vantage of the beautiful Big South Fork River. This trail is relatively flat and short, making it appropriate for families with young children. Consider camping at the nearby Bandy Creek campground, and consider this hike a day's excursion from there.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	1 hr 30 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	2.8
Elevation Change	Gentle
Pets	Allowed on leash
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Not Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Little Kids and Big Kids
Accessibility	Not Accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Grand Gap Loop Trailhead, G84V+69 Oneida, Tennessee

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 36.50549, -84.65664

This address is for the trailhead for the Grand Gap Loop, deep into the Big South Fork National River & Recreation Area. The address uses a Google Maps “Plus code,” as there is not a street address for the trailhead. Please note this only works for Google Maps. Turn right into the parking area from Alfred Smith Rd. Look for the Grand Gap Loop Trail to begin the hike.

Trail Description

Distance from Start		Description
0.0		Start on the Grand Gap Loop (part of the John Muir Trail - these hikes share a name at this point). Head counterclockwise on the loop trail; the other direction is a much longer way to the overlook.
0.85		Grave site.
1.0		Descend gently toward the overlook.
1.4		Overlook. Rest and picnic at the large rocky overlook atop the Big South Fork and Angel Falls. Then, turn around to return to the start.
2.8		Trailhead.

i The Provenance of Abrams Falls

Angel Falls is more a rapids than a waterfall (it’s not very tall), but there’s a history to its name: It was a waterfall until the 1940s, when it was dynamited to make the river more easily navigable by paddlers and boaters. It was only a little successful: the rapids are known as being impassable for all but the most intrepid whitewater paddlers.

Nearby

- **Stop by Bandy Creek.** Check out the Bandy Creek chapter for more details.
- **Hike the Angel Falls Trail—and others.** The Angel Falls Trail—not to be mistaken with the trail taken to the overlook featured in this hike—starts at the parking area beside the Leatherwood Ford Bridge. It follows the Big South Fork River to conclude with a close-up view of Angel Falls, but without the vista from the overlook. Also, the Big South Fork National River and Recreation Area has more than 300 miles of trails.

Trail 19 : Honey Creek

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-20-figure-01.jpg
- trail-20-map.jpeg
- jo-bsf-cliff.jpg
- honey creek sign.jpg
- jonah ladder honey creek.jpg

Overview

This hike is unreal! This trail features rope ladders, wooden ladders, gigantic sandstone walls, a scenic overlook, a trail that traverses *up* a river, and boulders you crawl over and through. It's spectacular and challenging. This is a memorable trail that exemplifies what makes the Cumberland Plateau region such a worthy complement to the Great Smoky Mountains National Park. Younger children may be able to hike the first half (traveling counterclockwise from the trailhead); you can walk the road back to the trailhead. The second half of the trail contains more challenging (but very beautiful) sections. Still, it's hard – probably the most difficult for most in this book, making it best for the older kiddo hiker. Oh, and you will definitely want to be prepared to get your feet wet on this hike!

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	1 hr 30 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	4.4
Elevation Change	Steep
Pets	Not Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Big kids and Pre-teens and older
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Honey Creek Trailhead and Parking Area, C8CX+G7 Allardt, Tennessee

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 36.42123, -84.65180

Navigate to the Honey Creek Trailhead. Note that there is also a Honey Creek Overlook, which is the incorrect start for this hike. The above address uses a Google Maps “Plus” code in lieu of a street address for this trailhead; it only works in Google Maps.

Park in one of the many spots at the trailhead. The trail begins slightly past the trailhead, on the other side of the road from the large signpost for the trailhead, slightly up the road. Look for the Honey Creek Loop Trail sign.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on the Honey Creek Loop Trail. Gently wind through the densely wooded forest.
0.2	Gently, then more steeply, descend through the woods.
0.9	Rope ladder.
1.05	Enter the section with high cliff walls along the left of the trail.
1.35	Trail splits to the left to head to the overlook. Ladders.
1.45	Overlook. After stopping at the overlook, head back down to resume the trail by turning left at the trail juncture. Or, optionally, walk the road back 0.8 miles to the parking area and trailhead.
1.75	Trail turns up into Honey Creek. Look for the green symbol with two hikers as a guide to follow the trail; in places, you’ll walk through the creek and through crevices and cracks in giant boulders!
2.25	Head up and away from the creek.
2.75	Wind through and around huge boulders and rocks. Continue to look for the green trail symbols.
3.0	Ice Castle Falls, a beautiful waterfall.
3.1	Gentle climb through a rocky, exposed section with different vegetation.
3.25	Short rope ladder.
3.3	Trail levels out, then climbs back to the start and the trailhead.
4.4	Trailhead.

i Sandstone

The Cumberland Plateau's sandstone cliffs tell their age in layers—tan and gray rock streaked with rust-orange where ancient iron has slowly rusted over millions of years. Water and time have carved dramatic overhangs called rockhouses, creating natural shelters that kids can't resist exploring. At Honey Creek, these bluffs tower overhead at nearly every turn.

Nearby

- **Grab a slushie!** This is one of the most remote—if not the most remote—hikes in this book. A favorite stop on the way back from Honey Creek is to quench our thirst by enjoying a slushie at the Pilot Travel Center (106 Comfort Ln, Pioneer, TN 37847) off exit 122 on I-75.

The Great Smoky Mountains National Park

Figures included in this chapter:

- maps/Smokies_Region_v6.jpg

This section includes information on 11 hikes in the Great Smoky Mountains National Park, or the Smokies. The Smokies are an astonishing place — high mountain ridges with plants reminiscent of the northern United States and even Canada; river and creek beds with abundant aquatic wildlife; a place of wild bears and stories and the history of both Cherokee and European settlers still present.

There's no way around these hikes being the heart of this book. That is not meant to diminish those close to Knoxville and the Cumberland Plateau, which in other parts of the country would stand apart as destinations in their own right. It just speaks to how special the Smokies can be.

That said, a note and a warning. The high number of visitors and the proximity of Knoxville have key for families: you can be choosy about when and where to go! While there are few things more special than a Smokies hike up, for example, a beautiful creek on a perfect Fall day, there are few things more challenging than being stuck in traffic, no trail in sight, with tired out kid, or ending up on a trail that feels more like a line at nearby Dollywood than a hike in the woods. But, this is the benefit of living in Knoxville, and even in the height of the summer, there are trails to visit—and times to visit—that will surprise you with how few people there are!

Trail 21: Spruce Flats Falls

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-21-figure-01.jpg
- spruce-flats-kids.jpg
- trillium.PNG

Overview

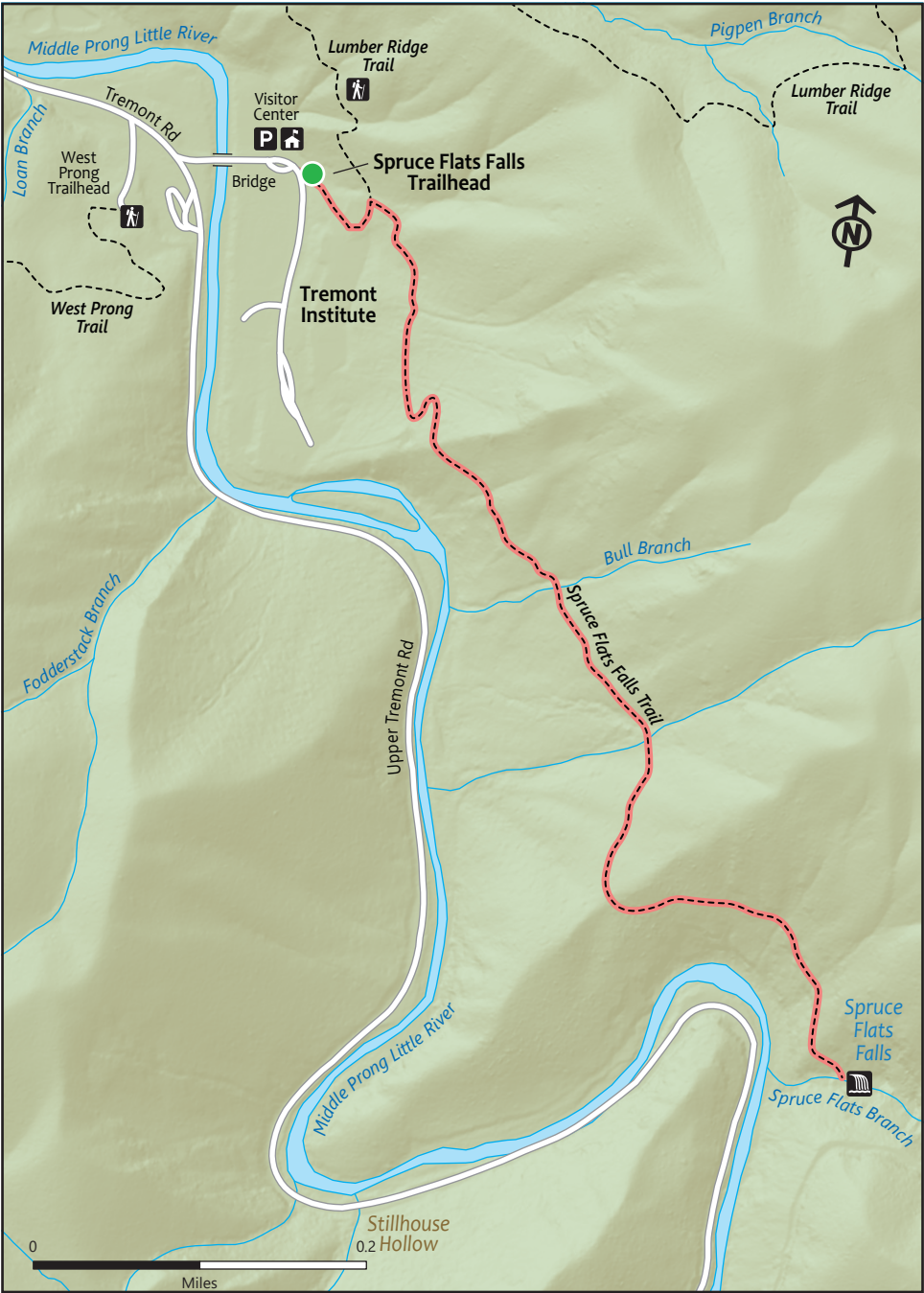
An adventurous hike in the Smokies accessible to many families, this hike is also a great introduction to the national park, particularly when visiting from around Knoxville (it's fairly close). It's on the Great Smoky Mountains Institute site at Tremont, a national leader in outdoors and environmental education. It is the first hike in this section for a good reason. The proximity to Townsend is a bonus. Best for little kids and big kids. We have hiked this trail with a two-month-old baby in wrap carrier! Just take your time and watch your footing. This (challenging, at time) hike is well worth it!

⚠ Important: Spruce Flat Falls requires special consideration. Spruce Flats Falls is an unofficial trail maintained by the Great Smoky Mountains Institute at Tremont, not the National Park Service. Heavy use has created erosion problems along the route. Respect this non-profit educational park partner by hiking only in small groups, staying on the designated path, and following our access directions carefully.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	50 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	1.6
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Not Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required
Restroom(s)	Yes
Best Ages	Big kids and Pre-teens and older

Characteristic	Details
Accessibility	Not accessible



Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: 9275 Tremont Rd, Townsend, TN 37882

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.64000, -83.68905

The address and coordinates are for the Great Smoky Mountains Institute, as this is the easiest-to-locate destination. When nearly there (less than a quarter of a mile from the destination), you'll cross a bridge to enter the Institute. You'll parking on the left near the gift shop; though the trailhead and Google Maps will navigate you a little further, the parking you see here is the best place to park. From a trail at the back of the parking lot, start on the Lumber Ridge Trail to begin this hike.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Though the main trail you take to the falls is the Buckeye Trail, you will start the hike on the Lumber Ridge Trail. Ample signage is available to help avoid confusion.
0.1	Turn right onto the Buckeye Trail.
0.15	Trail levels out before a steep climb.
0.3	Climb begins. It's a (good) challenge!
0.5	High point of the hike in a piney outcropping. Good photo spot. Begin to wind down toward the waterfall.
0.8	Spruce Flat Falls. A great snack or picnic spot. After a nice break, turn around the way you came.
1.6	Trailhead.

i Trillium

Native perennial plants with distinctive three-petal flowers that bloom in the spring. These shade-loving plants are often found in the forest understory, where their seeds are dispersed and buried by ants, in a process called myrmecochory. Trillium plants are protected in many places because they are extremely slow-growing. For some species, it can take anywhere from 5-9 years from being planted to their first bloom; a single plant can live up to 25 years! So, next time you see one, make sure you appreciate their beauty with your eyes only. - MaryRose Weatherton

Nearby

- **Stop at the Tremont store.** The gift store at Tremont (the full name is the Great Smoky Mountains Institute at Tremont) is usually open Monday—Friday from 10:00 a.m.—4:00 p.m.
- **Hike the West Prong trail.** This is a great nearby trail to a great picnic spot (at the site of Backcountry Site #18, across the road from the Great Smoky Mountains Institute at Tremont).
- **Visit Townsend.** See Chestnut Tops trail for more detail.

Trail 22: Little River

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-22-figure-02.jpg
- trail-22-map.jpeg
- little river rocks kids.jpeg
- hemlock.jpg

Overview

This hike is a great introduction to the Great Smoky Mountains National Park by featuring a bit of many of the elements that make the Smokies special: a trail along a beautiful, clear river; a waterfall; abundant plant and aquatic wildlife; deep forest; and a peek into Smokies history when you step into the cabins in the Elkmont Historic District. The hike starts at the Little River trailhead, following the Little River along its namesake river. Turn around near the small waterfall or continue the loop back to the trailhead. Great for kids of all ages, because there is not any one spot you must reach on the trail. Simply hike as far as you like and then head back to picnic or check out the historic cabins!

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	1 hour
Trail Distance (Miles)	5.5
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Not Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Little kids, Big kids, and Pre-teens and older
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Elkmont Campground, MC58+3H Gatlinburg

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.65346, -83.58005

Please note: the trailhead does not have a specific address and includes a “Plus code” to park at the start of the Little River Trail. If you navigate to “Elkmont Campground,” then look for signs to parking for the Little River Trail. Park and look for the gate across the gravel road, where the Little River Trail begins.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Pass around the gate (it’s closed only to vehicles) to begin on the Little River Trail.
0.1	Pass the Spence Cabin, a historic cabin that is available to rent for a daytime event!
0.45	Trail begins to ascend.
2.1	Huskey Branch Falls on the right side of the trail.
2.4	Reach the intersection of the Little River Trail and the Cucumber Gap Trail. Turn right onto the Cucumber Gap trail. Trail climbs up toward Cucumber Gap.
3.4	Cucumber Gap, the high point of this hike. Begin to descend.
4.65	Reach the intersection of Cucumber Gap Trail and Jakes Creek Trail. Turn right onto Jakes Creek Trail.
5.3	Reach Jakes Creek Road. Turn right to return to the trailhead.
5.5	Trailhead.

i Eastern Hemlock

A tree that feels” like the Smokies. Characterized by its needles being arranged in a flat frond. Threatened by an invasive species

Nearby

- **Visit the historic cabins.** The nearby historic cabins are a must-see. Kids love to duck into and out of many recently restored (and others in the process of being restored).
- **Camp at Elkmont campground.** The Elkmont Campground is scenic, large, and worth a visit, especially if you can reserve a spot beside the Little River.

Trail 23: Mouse Creek

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-23-map.jpeg
- BR2linedsalamader.png
- trail-23-figure-02.jpg
- big creek.jpg

Overview

Surprisingly close to Knoxville, given how remote and wild this trailhead and trail feels, Mouse Creek in the Big Creek area of the Smokies is quite a bit less well-known than many of the other trails in the Great Smoky Mountains National Park featured in this book. The creek that this trail follows looks otherworldly - clear and almost turquoise in color. This hike starts at a trailhead at the Big Creek Picnic Area, located beside the Big Creek Campground. The trail starts off a little steep, but the trail is wide and smooth; like the Middle Prong trail, this trail used to be a railroad bed. The trail follows above the creek and then returns closer to it, with Mouse Creek Falls as the turn-around. A good day-trip adventure for kids and families; the smooth grade makes this an achievable hike for little hikers.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	1 hr 5 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	4.0
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Not Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required
Restroom(s)	Yes (seasonal)
Best Ages	Little kids and big kids
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Big Creek Picnic Area, QV2R+H6 Newport

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.75132, -83.10964

Navigate to the Big Creek Picnic Area. Note that the above address uses a Google Maps “Plus code” in the absence of a street address for this picnic area; the plus code only works in Google Maps. The picnic area is at the end of a bumpy dirt road; it’s large and easy to find. You may note the Big Creek Trailhead on the way (it is on the right, immediately before the parking lot). Park and then backtrack a little on the road you took to the parking area to find the start of this trail. Kids may like to play around the picnic area (and the pretty bridge crossing Big Creek) before or after the hike!

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on the Big Creek Trail. Gradually ascend.
0.1	Ascend gradually on a wide path.
1.4	Midnight Hole Falls. Great swimming spot in the summer.
2.0	Mouse Creek Falls. Turn-around spot. Head back to the start. Optionally, continue farther on the trail.
4.0	Trailhead.

i Blue Ridge Two-Lined Salamander

The Great Smoky Mountains has more than 30 species of salamanders – one of the types of species that contributes to and characterizes the incredible biodiversity of the Smokies. The Blue Ridge Two-Lined Salamander is among the most beautiful salamanders, with its yellow-to-orange coloring and stark black stripes. - Amanda Garner

Nearby

- **Picnic at a lovely picnic area!** The Big Creek Picnic Area is one of the finest spots to picnic in the Great Smoky Mountains National Park. Start or end your hike with a picnic here.

Trail 24: Middle Prong

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-24-figure-01.jpg
- trail-24-map.jpeg
- jo-middle-prong.jpg
- middle prong.jpg

Overview

This hike is great for families looking to have an authentic hiking experience deep in the Smokies, while still being only a little over an hour's drive from Knoxville. A benefit of this hike is the early payoff on this scenic trail. It's only 0.6 miles to the waterfall, but along a stream that affords many chances to hop in and splash. The turn-around spot is an overlook to a waterfall, Lynn Camp Prong, though the trail continues after the cascades up to another waterfall, Indian Flats Falls. Given the ample shade and easy access to the stream, this is a great hike for the summer, but it is enjoyable in all seasons. Good for kids of all ages because you can turn around at any point.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	1 hr 5 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	Up to 7.6
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Not Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	All Ages
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Middle Prong Trail Trailhead, J89J+54 Townsend, Tennessee

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.61794, -83.66971

The above address will navigate you to the parking area for the trailhead. Please note it uses a “Plus code” in lieu of a street address that only works in Google Maps. Note that this trailhead is at the end of a lengthy gravel road, but it’s fairly smooth (and it’s a pretty drive). This is a large parking area. Even on the busiest days, you will be able to find a place to park. There are spots around the turn-around, but if they are taken, it is acceptable to park on the side of the road. After parking, walk toward the bridge to start your hike.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Cross the bridge over Lynn Camp Prong. Ascend gradually on the Middle Prong Trail.
0.05	Almost immediately past the bridge, not the split in the trail. This hike heads to the left. A short trail, the Thunderhead Prong Quiet Walkway, heads to the right (it’s a great place for kids to play and splash on hot days!).
0.65	Overlook to Lynn Camp Prong. Though a short way in, this is an acceptable spot to turn around and head back to the start. The trail continues onward. This is one of many trails in the Smokies that is pretty and very worthwhile all along the way; hike as far as you or your little ones like.
2.35	Intersection with Panther Creek Trail on the left. Continue on the Middle Prong Trail.
3.6	Begin a brief switchback before the waterfall at the end of this hike.
3.8	Reach Indian Flat Falls. It’s accessible via a small opening in the trees and shrubs. After resting at the beautiful waterfall, turn around to return to the start.
5.25	Intersection with the Panther Creek Trail on the right.
7.6	Trailhead

Brook Trout

The native species of trout in Smokies streams. Speckled and small. Found at high elevations, whereas the Rainbow Trout and Brown Trout were later introduced for fishing.

Nearby

- **Drive the Cade's Cove Loop.** This is a nice way to make a longer day of your trip. Instead of returning the way you came, at the intersection of Townsend Road and Laurel Creek Road, turn left and head toward Cade's Cove. The drive to Cade's Cove is around 15 minutes; the loop road around Cade's Cove takes around 45 minutes to drive—longer on busy days, especially when bears are visible—which is often! Traffic on the loop road can be severe, especially during peak times, so plan accordingly to avoid restless kiddos.
- **Stopping for a snack or meal in Townsend.** Townsend bills itself as the “Peaceful Side of the Smokies”. Peaceful Side Social is a favorite lunch and dinner spot with kids, owing to the good food and large outdoor play area.

Trail 25: Abrams Creek

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-25-figure-01.jpg
- trail-25-map.jpeg
- trail-25-figure-02.jpg

Overview

Abrams Creek is a great place to start hiking in the Smokies if you live in or around Knoxville. In fact, it is the first Smokies hike our family did when our oldest was only about four months old! It's accessible, offers a wide variety of features to please all members of the family, and has the added bonus of being beautiful! The enduring memory from this trail is of kids splashing endlessly in the shallow creeks. There are many ways to shorten the hike, and we often hike around a mile in and then turn around. It can be warmer here in the summer months, but the river offers many opportunities to swim and splash around, making it a great destination for the summer as well. This hike is relatively challenging beyond the first backcountry campsite, and better suited to hiking in its entirety with older children. The beauty of this hike is its versatility: you can turn around at many points along the trail and still have a great hike!

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	55 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	5.8
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Not Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required
Restroom(s)	Yes (seasonal)
Best Ages	All ages
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Abrams Creek Campground, J368+MR Tallassee, Tennessee

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.61095, -83.93356

It never seems to become crowded at Abrams Creek, but parking can be a bit confusing. This is because the first campground is further along the same road the trailhead is on. Also, there are two areas to park for the trailhead. We usually park by the gate to the campground, but you can also park near the large sign with maps of this area of the national park.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start at the trailhead parking area. Walk along the road beside Abrams Creek.
0.4	Arrive at the campground. A great spot to rest and hang out by the creek.
1.0	Cross Kingfisher Creek for the first time. Watch for rocks and branches to aid in crossing.
1.1	Cross Kingfisher Creek again about 100 yards past the first crossing.
1.3	Reach Backcountry Site #1. Frequently used by overnight backpackers; a good resting spot. We often turn around here!
1.5	Reach the top of the ridge after a steep climb. Another great place to stop and rest (or turn around). Or continue for a grand adventure.
1.6	Arrive at the overlook with views of Abrams Creek and Gregory Bald in the distance.
2.0	Return to Abrams Creek near its intersection with Buckshank Branch. A great spot to relax and splash in the creek.
2.8	Reach Backcountry Site #17. Turn around here to head back to the start.
4.3	Return to Backcountry Site #1.
5.6	Trailhead.

i The Cherokee

The people of the Cherokee Nation were indigenous to a vast area to the south, east, and west of the Smokies; the Smokies were more a place for gathering and hunting than residing. The Eastern Band of the Cherokee remains an autonomous Nation just south of the Smokies.

i Smallmouth Bass

The smallmouth bass is Tennessee's state fish. This sunfish species can be identified by the lines on its face and a jaw (maxilla) that does not go past the eye (smaller). They are fantastic gamefish and are often the top predator in the streams and creeks of Tennessee. - Alex Edwards

Nearby

- **Visit the Look Rock Overlook.** Check the Look Rock Overlook hike for a short, nearby hike to a pretty overlook.
- **Camping at Abrams Creek Campground.** This is a lovely creekside campground that you pass on this hike. Consider a stay in the summer, when jumping in the cool, not-too-deep creek can be a respite from the heat—or in the fall when this area pops with fall colors.

Trail 26: Look Rock

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-26-figure-01.jpg
- trail-26-map.jpeg
- fir.jpg

Overview

This is a short but rewarding overlook hike that is just a moderate drive from Knoxville. The entire hike is paved, but the trail is steep. Start at a parking area with a very scenic overlook. The trail starts out steep but then levels out. At the top is a tower that affords views of the Smokies as well as the Tennessee Valley and Knoxville. Clear days are more often found in the winter, spring, and fall (after the humidity drops). Consider coupling with a drive along the Foothills Parkway, or take visitors here after you pick them up from the airport in nearby Maryville, as we have with our parents! This is a fun family hike with littles that serve as a nice and usually not crowded introduction to the Smokies.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	45 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	0.6
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Not Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Toddlers and Little Kids
Accessibility	Partially accessible (paved but very steep)

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Look Rock Lower Overlook, 7210 Flats Rd, Tallassee, TN 37878

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.63099, -83.94083

The above address takes you to a large parking lot with a scenic overlook. Park, and look for the scenic overlook, the Murry Gap Overlook. From there, walk along the back of the parking lot, and then along a sidewalk. Cross the road to the Look Rock Trail to begin the hike.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start at the Murry Gap Overlook.
0.15	Cross the road to the Look Rock Trail.
0.35	Intersection. Turn left to continue on the Look Rock Trail.
0.4	Weather station to the right. Continue on the trail.
0.5	Reach the overlook. Climb the ramp to reach the top—and take a look in all directions! Return back down the ramp to return to the start.
0.65	Intersection. Turn right to return to the parking lot and trailhead.
1.0	Trailhead.

Fraser Fir

You'll feel like you're in a different state or country when you spot these trees atop the Smokies – usually at elevations above 5,500 feet. Note the Christmas tree smell! From Look Rock, you can see the ridge of the Smokies where Fraser Firs grow. Afflicted by the Balsam Woolly Adelgid and potentially a changing climate around the ridge of the Smokies.

Nearby

- **Visit Abrams Creek.** See the Abrams Creek hike for a nearby, lengthier expedition.
- **Drive the Foothills Parkway.** On the way to the trailhead for this hike, you briefly drove on the Foothills Parkway, Tennessee's scenic parkway that receives far fewer visits than the well-known Blue Ridge Parkway. This is an underrated road featuring scenic overlooks of the Smokies and limited traffic.

Trail 27: Chestnut Top

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-27-figure-01.jpg
- trail-27-map.jpeg

Overview

Steep but quiet and rewarding, Chestnut Top is a fun choice for a shorter hike in the Great Smoky Mountains National Park. This hike is one of the closest to Knoxville. Furthermore, it is close to the amenities of Townsend, a far quieter town than Pigeon Forge and Gatlinburg. The trail starts with a steep climb until it reaches a rocky point that is a great stopping point; we always grab a snack here, and kiddos like to hike on or around the rocks. The trail continues along the trail past pretty mountain laurel, typically in bloom around mid-May through early June, stopping at a fun but somewhat arbitrary point: a hollow tree! Continue further if you like, or head back to the start and the Townsend Wye, a great picnic and water play spot. Best for kids who are comfortable with a steady climb, and little kids may need a boost.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	45 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	2.6
Elevation Change	Steep
Pets	Not Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required
Restroom(s)	No
Best Ages	Big kids
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Townsend Wye, Laurel Creek Rd & Little River Rd, Townsend, TN 37882

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.66027, -83.70839

This address is for the Townsend Wye, a prominent intersection between Townsend, the road to Gatlinburg (Little River Gorge Rd.), and the road to Cades Cove (Laurel Creek Road) and one of the best-known summer swimming spots in the Smokies. Park in the large parking area on the left of the Townsend Entrance Rd. on which you entered if coming from Knoxville and Townsend. The trail begins across the Townsend Entrance Road. Look for a sign across the road for the Chestnut Top Trail.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on the Chestnut Top Trail. Ascend steeply.
0.6	Trail levels out. Townsend visible from the trail.
0.70	Rocky outcropping. Great place for a break and for kids to scramble up and around the rocks. Look for Mountain Laurel a little bit up the trail that flowers around May and June.
1.3	Hollow Tree. This is the turn-around spot for this hike. Alternatively, if you like, head farther up the trail!
2.6	Trailhead.

Mountain Laurel

A large bush in the same family as Rhododendron and Blueberries - Heath plants. Beautiful flowers around early June. Can be distinguished from Rhododendron by its location: typically on ridges away from water.

Nearby

- **Visit Townsend.** Townsend rightly contrasts itself with busy Pigeon Forge and Gatlinburg; it remains quiet but full of places to stop. We love the kid-friendly Peaceful Side Social (7967 E Lamar Alexander Pkwy, Townsend, TN 37882) and the next-door Peaceful Side Creamery.

- **Swim at the Townsend Wye.** This is a classic summertime Smokies activity. From the large parking area near the trailhead, swim in the Little River beside the Townsend Wye, the three-way intersection of Townsend Entrance Road (toward Townsend), Laurel Creek Road (to Cades Cove), and Little River Gorge Road (toward Gatlinburg).

Trail 28: Abrams Falls

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-28-figure-01.jpg
- jonah-horse.jpeg

Overview

This is a classic Smokies hike along the scenic Abrams Creek, ending in an epic waterfall. The only downside? You must drive (or, on many Wednesdays in the summer, bike!) through Cades Cove to get to the trailhead, and Cades Cove is often busy. We recommend either being prepared for extensive traffic in Cades Cove or visiting during the week or outside of the busy warm weather weekends. With that caveat in mind, we recommend this as a true day-long family adventure worthy of a visit. The trail starts at a scenic trailhead near the intersection of two pretty creeks. it hikes through the piney forest, climbing a little at a few points. Abrams Falls is a wonderful spot for a lengthy picnic before returning to the start. Best for older children or younger children who are carried when their little legs get tired.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	1 hr 30 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	5.0
Elevation Change	Steep
Pets	Not allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required
Restroom(s)	Yes
Best Ages	Big kids and Pre-teens and older
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Abrams Falls Trailhead, H4RW+CX Townsend, Tennessee

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.59129, -83.85233

Navigate to this parking area at the end of a short gravel road connected to the Cades Cove Loop Rd. Lots of parking. Look for a sign pointing toward the Abrams Falls Trail and Abrams Fall.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on the Abrams Fall Trail, crossing a bridge over the scenic Abrams Creek soon after you start.
0.1	Wind along the path through a pine forest.
1.1	Rocky prominence that serves as a scenic overlook.
2.2	Small hill beside and atop Abrams Falls. Take the trail briefly, steeply down to the bottom of the waterfall.
2.5	Reach the base of the waterfall. There are many spots to stop and snack or picnic. Take care to watch from a distance and not swim in the pool of the falls here; the undertone is dangerous. After a break, turn around to begin the back portion of this out-and-back hike.
5.0	Trailhead.

Black Bear

A symbol of the wildness of the Smokies – and a very real presence. If you see one, admire their strength, beauty, and intelligence (from a distance!). Commonly seen in nearby Cades Cove. Here is a photo of a mother bear and cubs forage near the trail — time to back away quietly

Nearby

- **Visit the Visitor Center.** The Cades Cove Visitor Center (5686 Cades Cove Loop Rd, Townsend, TN 37882) up the road is a store, but it also abuts several nearby historical structures that are worth a visit: the Cades Cove Historical Grist Mill and the John P Cable Drive Thru Barn (that you walk across, rather than drive through!). Try to find your way to Mill Creek to cool off in warm weather.

- **Stop at historic cabins and scenic lookouts.** Though it can be busy with traffic, especially during peak visitation periods (summer and fall weekends, in particular), a drive through Cades Cove is punctuated with numerous opportunities to stop at historic cabins and scenic lookouts. Plus, much of the year, you and others will stop to see wildlife such as deer, turkey, and often bears!
- **Bike the Cades Cove Loop.** Biking the Cades Cove Loop on car-free Wednesdays during the summer and into the early fall is a classic Smokies activity. We know it's a lot for kids to bike (or be carried out on a bike) and to hike, so this may be best as a separate day trip.

Trail 29: Andrews Bald

Figures included in this chapter:

- andrews bald.jpg
- trail-29-map.jpeg
- trail-29-figure-02.jpg
- red cheeked.PNG

Overview

Andrews Bald is the under-rated twin to Kuwohi (formerly known as Clingman's Dome). Kuwohi is the highest point in the Great Smoky Mountains National Park, the highest point in Tennessee, and among the highest in the Eastern United States. Why Andrews Bald instead of Kuwohi? The path to Kuwohi is often exceptionally crowded. It is still worth a visit, but Andrews Bald is as exceptional or moreso in some ways: instead of reaching a crowded overlook, Andrews Bald is a grassy bald overlooking layers of mountains. Pair it with a trip to Kuwohi or a stop at Newfound Gap, perhaps catching sunset after an afternoon Andrew's Bald hike. One memorable experience for us: we saw a bear on this trail, our first as a family. The hike has some rocky elements, and it can be lengthy, so we recommend this hike for older children.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	1 hr 45 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	3.6
Elevation Change	Moderate
Pets	Not Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required
Restroom(s)	Yes (seasonal)
Best Ages	Big kids and Pre-teens and older
Accessibility	Not accessible

Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Kuwohi Trailhead, HG43+QG Bryson City, North Carolina

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.55680, -83.49617

The above address is for the trailhead for Kuwohi, formerly named Clingman's Dome until it was renamed to its traditional name to the Cherokee in 2023. Parking here can be difficult to find during busy periods (especially during the summer and on weekends during the fall).

Consider visiting outside of these busy periods to avoid being stuck waiting to find a spot. After finding a spot, walk toward the Kuwohi Visitor Center. Look for the signs for the Forney Ridge Trail (it's just a few feet to the left along the same path as the Kuwohi Trail).

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.01	Start on the Forney Ridge Trail.
0.2	Intersection with the Kuwohi Bypass Trail. Turn left.
0.25	A moderately rocky but well-maintained section that descends. Steep in sections.
1.0	Wooden walkways over a section that can be muddy.
1.05	Intersection with the Forney Creek Trail — different from the Forney Ridge Trail. Stay on the Forney Ridge trail to continue to Andrews Bald.
1.8	Andrews Bald. Explore the super-scenic, grassy area before turning back.
2.55	Intersection with Forney Creek Trail. Stay on the Forney Ridge Trail.
3.4	Intersection with the Kuwohi Bypass Trail. Turn right.
3.6	Trailhead.

Jordans Red Cheek

These iconic Smokies salamanders are found only in the Smokies! If you are above 2,500 ft, you might just see one of these amazing critters. - Amanda Garner

Nearby

- **Visit Kuwohi (Clingman's Dome).** Nearby Kuwohi and the Kuwohi Trail to access this peak feature an observation tower with views in all directions. There's also the

nearby Kuwhohi Visitor Center. Both the trail and visitor center share the same parking area.

- **Stop at Newfound Gap.** On the way to Andrews Bald, you pass Newfound Gap, the mountain pass and scenic overlook atop the state line between Tennessee and North Carolina. This is a good place to stop for photos or a brief (or lengthier!) hike on the Appalachian Trail that runs through the parking lot, and toward the popular scenic overlook Charlie's Bunion, a steep, challenging eight-mile round-trip hike from Newfound Gap.

Trail 30: Alum Cave Bluffs

Figures included in this chapter:

- trail-30-figure-01.jpg
- trail-30-map.jpeg
- trail-30-figure-02.jpg
- rhodo.PNG
- spruce.jpeg
- leconte-sunset.jpeg

Overview

This is a hike up arguably *the* finest trail in the Great Smoky Mountains National Park. The trail starts at a pretty trailhead along Highway 441, the main road through the park. The trail continues along the super scenic Alum Cave Creek. The trail is very well-maintained and best hiked by older children. The trail climbs through a unique geological feature you hike *through*, Arch Rock, then heads up more steeply toward Mt. LeConte. The trail then crosses an overlook surrounded by Mountain Laurel before climbing farther toward Alum Cave, yet another unique geological feature, Alum Cave, you hike *beneath*. It's epic. This is a perfect spot for a rest and a picnic before returning to the trailhead. This is a challenging hike, and finding parking can also be a difficult, but it is worth the investment of time and effort, particularly for older kids or kids who have done a lot of hiking with friends and family.

Key Characteristics

Characteristic	Details
Time from Knoxville	1 hr 15 mins
Trail Distance (Miles)	4.5
Elevation Change	Very Steep
Pets	Not Allowed
Parking Pass/Entrance Fee	Required
Restroom(s)	Yes (seasonal)
Best Ages	Big kids and Pre-teens and older
Accessibility	Not accessible

Characteristic	Details
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Directions to the Trailhead

Trailhead Address: Alum Cave Trailhead Parking Area, 3639 Newfound Gap Rd, Gatlinburg, TN 37738

Trailhead GPS Coordinates: 35.62872, -83.45076

This is one of the busiest parking areas and trailheads in the park. Particularly with children, visiting during periods that are less busy can be essential for quickly finding a spot. Try to park at one of the two parking areas immediately beside the trailhead (one alongside the road, the other near the seasonal toilet). If you cannot, other parking is available, but from those you have to walk along the side of the road to reach the trailhead. After finding a spot, look for the signs for the Alum Cave Trail.

Trail Description

Distance from Start	Description
0.0	Start on the Alum Cave Trail. Almost immediately cross a bridge over the West Prong of the Little Pigeon River.
0.1	Continue on the trail, now along Alum Cave Creek. The trail gradually climbs up a wide, scenic pathway, occasionally crossing
0.6	Fun spots to splash in the creek about around this section. Pick one and cool off in warmer weather!
1.3	Cross a bridge and then climb up the stairs through Arch Rock. This is an optional point at which to turn-around and return to the start.
1.4	Cross a footlog and enter a different part of the hike, one where you will ascend more steeply (though the trail remains moderately steep here).
1.9	Reach inspiration point, a rocky prominence and scenic overlook — and a great point to pause or return back to the start, though the bluffs are only a bit further.
2.2	Steep climb up stairs. Almost there!
2.25	Alum Cave Bluffs. Rest, soak in the views, and get ready for the return hike (almost all downhill!). The trail to Mount LeConte continues past the bluffs.
4.5	Trailhead.

i Rosebay Rhododendron

These plants are commonly seen on slopes near streams, which helps stabilize the soil. Looks similar to Mountain Laurel; has larger leaves. Pretty, but all parts of this plant are toxic to humans and pets! You can't miss the Rosebay Rhododendron on this hike around inspiration point. -MaryRose Weatherton

i Red Spruce

Similar to Fraser Fir, but larger (taller and wider) and found at lower elevations (beginning around 4,000 feet). Majestic. When you see them, you feel like you're in high and remote mountains.

Nearby

- **Visit Sevierville, Pigeon Forge, and Gatlinburg.** Sevierville, Pigeon Forge, and Gatlinburg loosely form a corridor from I-40 to the entrance to the Great Smoky Mountains National Park. Sevierville and (especially) Pigeon Forge feature tourist attractions, restaurants, and a very wide variety of shops; Gatlinburg is touristy but has a more small-town character. As tourist destinations, all three can be busy, but they can be fun places to stop with happy but tired kiddos, and restaurants and shopping are plentiful.
- **Hike on to LeConte for a grand adventure!** You may continue farther along on the Alum Cave Trail to Mount LeConte, a peak with only around 40 feet less height than Kuwohi, but only accessible via (lengthy) hikes. The round trip hike from the Alum Cave Trail Trailhead to Mount LeConte is around 11 very challenging miles. There is a lodge at which you can reserve a rustic room called LeConte Lodge (LeConte Lodge · Gatlinburg, TN 37738), but it can be difficult to secure a reservation. The LeConte Lodge includes a store where day hikers can purchase snacks, coveted t-shirts, and even more coveted no-bake cookies.

Doing More

Deepening the Experience

Figures included in this chapter:

- jo-levi-backpack.jpg
- leconte-summit.jpeg

You’ve made it a good number of miles; what’s next? This chapter speaks to ways of deepening the experience of hiking with little ones.

Grow as a hiking family

If you’re anything like us, you’ll have rough days on the trail.

Further, if you’re like us, there may be seasons (or even entire years!) when hiking doesn’t quite “fit” like it has at other times.

We think that’s okay. A joy of spending time outdoor with family is that there do not need to be high expectations. We don’t need to hike all of the time or to have the latest outdoors gear. Instead, you—and we—can think of ourselves as growing as a hiking family.

Does the future hold yearly family outings to Seven Islands? Epic adventures into the depth of the Smokies? We don’t know where the memories we are forming now might lead; maybe that is part of the joy of hiking with little ones.

Invite friends and family to join

Some of our best memories hiking come from inviting friends and family—especially those new to hiking. Like you may have with your kids, start small and take your time; maybe your kids can lead your guests!

Go farther

Many of the hikes in this book are on a small part of longer trails. For example, the Alum Cave Bluffs hike in the previous chapter is around one-half of the way to the top of Mount LeConte, an epic hike to a truly majestic scenic overlook, Cliff Tops. You should try it after you develop confidence making it to the Bluffs. Particularly in the Smokies and the Cumberland Plateau, you can go (much) farther if you like. Which leads to our next two points.

Camp

A great way to be closer to trailheads (and to have more time for long hikes) is to camp. If you haven't gone before, consider asking friends to join.

Here are some favorite campgrounds; all have online systems that make it easy to reserve a spot:

- *Frozen Head State Park, Big Cove*: the ideal family campground, quiet, with giant boulders and a nearby creek for kids to splash in, clean restrooms, a playground, and even a rustic library nearby.
- *Smokies campgrounds*:
 - *Cades Cove*: The place to camp if you want to explore or bike (on Wednesdays in the summer and early fall) the Cades Cove Loop
 - *Elkmont*: Sprawling, and a little less spread out feeling than Cades Cove, but also a bit more scenic. Look for a site along the Little River.
 - *Cosby*: A hidden gem and one of our family's favorites, with perhaps the most featureful quiet nature trail (not officially a trail in the Smokies!) that is connected to the campground. Mostly tent spots; has just a few spots for recreational vehicles.
- *Bandy Creek Campground*: In Big South Fork, this is a modern, spacious, friendly campground that seems to never approach being full. Close to many great hiking trails—and the horse stables.

Try backpacking (really!)

Like for camping, if you've never been or considered backpacking, consider asking friends who have if they would like to go. These are often referred to as "backcountry" sites (in contrast to the "frontcountry" sites in campgrounds).

Here are some favorite spots for backpacking:

- *Smokies*:

- *Backcountry Site #1*: You’ll see this on the Abrams Creek trail. Being only a one-mile hike to the site, this is a great first spot.
 - *Backcountry Site #17*: Also on the Abrams Creek trail, but considerably farther than Backcountry site #1. Super scenic, with many spots spread out in a bend of the creek.
 - *Backcountry Site #18*: Accessible from two trails, this site is nestled along a beautiful creek crossed by a bridge.
 - *Kephart Shelter*: One of 15 *shelters*, three-sided structures with two-level wooden floors for an easier setup (no tent required!). This shelter is a gentle and pleasant hike, but is a long drive from Knoxville.
 - *Icewater Springs Shelter*: A steep, around two-mile hike along the Appalachian trail is the path to this shelter.
- *Frozen Head State Park*:
 - *Bird Mountain*: A steep but pleasant hike up to one of the ridges of Frozen Head State Park. Passes Castle Rock, a unique and fun geologic feature.

Recommended Resources

Other Hiking Guides

- Molloy, J. (2015). *Best tent camping: Tennessee: Your car-camping guide to scenic beauty, the sounds of nature, and an escape from civilization* (2nd ed.). Menasha Ridge Press.
- Molloy, J. (2012). *Explorer's guide 50 hikes on Tennessee's Cumberland Plateau*. Countryman Press.
- Molloy, J. (2021). *Five-star trails: Knoxville: 40 spectacular hikes in the heart of East Tennessee* (2nd ed.). Menasha Ridge Press.
- Wise, K. (2014). *Hiking trails of the Great Smoky Mountains: Comprehensive guide*. University of Tennessee Press.
- Hubbs, H., Maynard, C., & Morris, D. (2020). *Family Hiking in the Smokies*. University of Tennessee Press.

History

- Brewer, A., & Brewer, C. (1975). *Valley so wild: A folk history*. East Tennessee Historical Society.
- Bridges, A., Clement, R., & Wise, K. (Eds.). (2019). *The Terra Incognita reader: Early writings from the Great Smoky Mountains*. University of Tennessee Press.
- Howell, B. J. (2003). *Folklife along the Big South Fork of the Cumberland River*. University of Tennessee Press.

Science/Natural History

- Linzey, D. W. (2008). *A natural history guide to Great Smoky Mountains National Park*. University of Tennessee Press.

Field Guides

- Kemp, S. (1993). *Trees of the Smokies*. Great Smoky Mountains Association.
- Tilley, S. G., & Huheey, J. E. (2001). *Reptiles and amphibians of the Smokies*. Great Smoky Mountains Association.

- White, P. (2000). *Wildflowers of the Smokies*. Great Smoky Mountains Association.

General Advice on Hiking and Going Outdoors with Kids

- Aist, J. (2019). *Babes in the woods: Hiking, camping & boating with babies and young children*. The Mountaineers Books.
- Alexander, K. (2017). *The backpacking with kids handbook: Your down and dirty guide to fun outdoor adventures with your kids*. Independently published.
- Ross, C. (2018). *The world is our classroom: How one family used nature and travel to shape an extraordinary education*. Skyhorse Publishing.

For Children

- Davis, J. P., & Blevins, H. (2021). *Outdoor school: Hiking and camping, the definitive interactive nature guide*. Odd dot.
- Ferrell, A. (2019). *The Hike*. Chronicle Books.
- Oswald, P. (2020). *Hike*. Candlewick Press.

Join, Participate, and Give Back

You may wish to join organizations that advocate for outdoors areas, or give back through donating time or money. Here are some ways to do so.

Join local organizations

Several local organizations advocate for and support the outdoors around Knoxville in critical ways, from maintaining trails

- *Friends of the Smokies* (<https://friendsofthesmokies.org/>): Works with the National Park Service to advocate for the Smokies
- *Smokies Life* (<https://smokieslife.org/>): Previously the Great Smoky Mountains Association; manages the stores throughout the park; can purchase parking permits for the National Park at those stores or online through their website
- *Smoky Mountains Hiking Club* (<https://www.smhclub.org/>): A longstanding hiking club that organizes multiple hikes in every month of the year
- *Legacy Parks Foundation* (<https://legacyparks.org/>): Preserves green space, creates trails, and provides access to waterways around Knoxville

Participate in programs at local outdoors education centers

One way to be part of a community is to participate in programs at local outdoors education centers.

- *Ijams* (<https://www.ijams.org/>): A nature center with a variety of programs and events
- *Great Smoky Mountains Institute at Tremont* (<https://gsmit.org/>): A nationally-recognized outdoors and environmental education center located within the National Park; has experiential education programs throughout the year for kids and adults

Give back

You can donate to all of the above, though participating in their programs or purchasing products from them is a great way to support them. You can also give of your time by volunteering.

- *Ijams* (<https://www.ijams.org/volunteer>)
- *The Great Smoky Mountains National Park* (<https://www.nps.gov/grsm/getinvolved/volunteer.htm>)
- *The Big South Fork National River and Recreation Area* (<https://www.nps.gov/biso/getinvolved/volunteer.htm>)

Apart from formally volunteering, you can be a great steward of the trails on which you hike by following the principles of *Leave No Trace* (see the Appendix for more details), and if you can, pick up trash from your favorite trails, and move branches or brush off the trail to make the path for the next little hiker a little better.

End Matter

About the Authors

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Appendix

LKBA - Appendix

Leave No Trace: Keeping the Wilderness Wild

These help preserve outdoor spaces for future adventurers.

1. Plan Ahead and Prepare

Check weather conditions before you go, and consider checking the website for the area you'll be hiking in to ensure the trail is open and in good condition (the vast majority of the time, trails are open!). Pack appropriate gear and extra supplies, especially since you'll be hiking with littles.

2. Travel and Camp on Durable Surfaces

Whenever possible, keep to established trails and campsites (we know one of our little hikers had a different tip in an earlier chapter!). Walk single file down the middle of the path - this protects trailside plants and prevents unnecessary erosion. When camping, look for hard, dry ground or existing sites that can handle the impact.

3. Pack It In, Pack It Out

Everything you bring must leave with you - food scraps, hygiene products, all of it. For bathroom breaks, if you can't make it to a bathroom, look to go at least 200 feet from water sources. For number #2, try to dig a hole to prevent run off.

4. Leave What You Find

The outdoors is full of treasures. Admire them, photograph them, but it's best to leave them where they are.

5. Minimize Campfire Impact

If you need or want to have a fire (when camping), use established rings or fire pans. Keep it small, stick to local dead wood, and ensure it's completely cold before you leave.

6. Respect Wildlife

Watch animals from a distance - no following, no feeding, no disturbing their homes. Store food securely and keep garbage out of reach. If you bring a doggy, keep them under control and away from wildlife.

7. Be Considerate

The wilderness is for everyone. One small part of trail etiquette is to yield to those hiking *up* on a trail (it's okay and understandable if little ones don't consistently do this, but it's a nice start to mention to those who are older!).

Optional Gear

Consider these additions based on your route and conditions:

Water Gear

- Water shoes
- Spare socks
- Change of clothes
- A towel

Weather Protection

- Long-sleeve shirt
- Warmer layer (fleece, wool)
- Rain shell or windbreaker

Extra Equipment

- Trekking poles (great for crossing creeks!)
- Child carriers if needed
- Sunscreen
- Insect repellent
- Emergency whistle (teach kiddos to use it if they get lost!)

First-Aid Essentials

Basic Kit

Perfect for day hikes and short adventures, here are just the basics that may be helpful to have:

1. Bandages in various sizes
2. Antibiotic ointment
3. Tweezers
4. Pain relievers
5. After bite stick (for bug bites)